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The Body at Work
Literary Representations of Labor in Medieval Iceland

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The Body at Work: Literary Representations of Labor in Medieval Iceland

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Ágrip

Í ritgerð þessari er leitast við að varpa ljósi á það hvernig íslenskar fornsögur draga upp mynd af líkamlegri vinnu. Þótt margir fræðimenn hafi leitast við að endurskapa félagslegar, efnahagslegar og lagalegar aðstæður sem ríktu á Íslandi á miðöldum, hafa fáir fjallað um almenn viðhorf Íslendinga á miðöldum til tilverunnar, og þá sérstaklega ekki til líkamlegrar vinnu. Í inngangi rannsóknarinnar er fjallað um sagnfræðilega hefð sem kenna má við frjálshyggju þar sem hinum „frjálsa norræna bónda“ er hampað. Hann átti sjálfur jörð sína í samfélagi þar sem var tiltölulega lítið um skipulag og stigveldi. Gegn þessu er því haldið fram að félagslegar breytingar samfara samþjöppun eigna hafi haft úrslitaáhrif á það hvernig Ísland þróaðist í áranna rás, og að bæði sagnaritararnir og ætlaðir viðtakendur sagnanna hafi verið meðvitaðir um þessar breytingar. Samfélagið greindist í þrjá hópa, eins og það birtist í miðaldabókmenntum: þrælar, frjálsir menn og höfðingjar, en myndin sem dregin er upp af þessum hópum kemur á mismunandi hátt fram í sögunum. Þó það komi á óvart hvað birtingarmynd þessara hópa er fjölbreytt, er eigi að síður hægt að fullyrða að fyrir hvern hópinn megi sjá eðilegt og óeðlilegt samband við líkamlega vinnu. Það má setja í samband við eðli félagslegra tengsla í íslensku miðaldasamfélagi. Þrælar eru gjarnan settir á sama stall og húsdýr og í lýsingu á vinnu þeirra er oft lögð áhersla á líkamleika þeirra. Aftur á móti þurfa frjálsir menn að sinna skyldum leiguliðans, greiða gjöld og jafnframt vinna landbúnaðarverk. Mesti fjölbreytileikinn er ef til vill hjá höfðingjunum, en þeim er í senn lýst sem upprennandi aðli, um leið og þeir fá virðingu og réttlætingu sem búhöldar sem gjarnan taka sjálfir til hendinni. Niðurstaðan er að sögurnar endurspeglar ekki hagsmuni einnar stéttar, þótt viðhorf höfðingja séu áberandi, heldur mjög sundurleita blöndu af viðhorfum sem rekja rætur sínar til átaka og breytinga sagnaritunartímans.

Abstract

This work seeks to understand the representation of labor in the medieval Icelandic sagas. Where much scholarship has been devoted to reconstructing the social, economic, and legal conditions that prevailed in medieval Iceland, fewer works have been devoted to the medieval Icelandic worldview generally, and attitudes towards labor more specifically. Framing the discussion is an intervention into the liberal historiographical tradition referred to as the “free Viking peasant,” which stressed the relative importance of freeholding farmers, and relative absence of structures and hierarchy. Against this, it is argued that the social changes and concentration of wealth were not just decisive in the historical development of Iceland, but also that both saga authors and audience seem to have been aware of these changes. Three major classes are identified in the medieval literature: slaves, free laborers, and chieftains, and the representation of these classes is broken down into different tropes that expand across the saga corpus. Although we do find surprising heterogeneity in the representations of these groups, we can nevertheless state that for each of these social groups, there are appropriate and inappropriate relationships to labor which speak more generally to the social relations of medieval Iceland. Slaves are symbolically aligned with the animal and their labor often emphasizes their embodiment, whereas free laborers had to navigate the duties of tenantry, rent-paying, and of course the realities of agricultural labor. Where we perhaps find the greatest diversity is with the chieftains, who are simultaneously represented as a budding aristocratic class, while also drawing pride and legitimation from their role as farmers. What we find is not one monolithic class interest reflected in the sagas, although the chieftain interest is indeed strong, but a highly heterogenous mixture of beliefs that speaks to the tensions and transformations of the age of saga production.

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1. Introduction

William Morris stands out as perhaps one of the most interesting figures in the reception history of medieval Icelandic literature. Along with his collaborator, Eiríkir Magnússon, he was one of the first modern translators of the sagas of Icelanders into English. And unlike many reactionary intellectuals of the 19th century who saw in the “epics of the North” justification for empire,¹ Morris’s peculiar socialist Medievalism saw in medieval Icelandic literature a monument *against* empire and for a kind of rugged proto-liberalism.² Far from a heroic glorification of past greatness, medieval Icelandic literature came to stand for the strength of those who have nothing else but endurance and storytelling:

O hearken, ye who speak the English Tongue,
How in a waste land ages long ago,
The very heart of the North bloomed into song
After long brooding o’er this tale of woe!
Hearken, and marvel how it might be so. [...]
Or rather marvel not, that those should cling
Unto the thoughts of great lives passed away
Whom God has stripped so bare of everything,
Save the one longing to wear through their day,
In fearless wise.³

Especially attractive to Morris was his understanding of Nordic pre-Christian cosmology. Originally drawn to the Arthurian grail romances, Morris sought in these narratives the potential for transcendence, and as his political thinking developed, transcendence in these grail romances became connected to radical social transformation, e.g. the Marxist Revolution. In the stories of the mythical Scandinavian

¹ On Morris’s contemporary, Carlyle, and his more conservative politicization of Norse mythology, see: O’Donoghue, *From Asgard to Valhalla*, 156.

² Ashurst, “William Morris and the Volsungs,” 51.

³ Morris, *Works* VII, 289.

past, however, Morris encountered what he perceived as a very different cosmos and worldview, its tragic downfall already foretold. In Morris's thinking, Norse cosmology presents nothing to be overcome nor transcended. Rather, Norse mythological thinking offers a way to tragically affirm the immanence of this world. "This reconceived ideal of what it meant to live heroically," writes Ian Felce, "would go on to influence his subsequent attitude towards art, craft and design, society and government, cultural history and its preservation, as well as his later inclination to create popular myths in the form of prose fantasy."⁴ Morris conceived of Marxism as a fundamentally Christian system, based on a moral Fall out of a previous, Edenic state and the awaiting of a better world to come. But as Morris's thinking developed, he became increasingly pessimistic about the ability for humans to permanently change the world for the better. His epic poem, *The Story of Sigurd the Volsung and the Fall of the Nibelungs*, can be seen as his struggle to unite a revolutionary socialism with a tragic historiography: "There as thou drawest thy sword, thou shalt think of the days that were, / And the foul shall still seem foul, and the fair shall still seem fair."⁵ For Morris, heroic action came not from trying to *overcome* the horrors and suffering of history, but instead, by finding ways to affirm the difficulties and labors of this world. What Morris saw in the literature of medieval Iceland might be considered as an encounter between Marx and Nietzsche: "it may be seen that the eschatological vision of the poem has little in common with the Marxists' end of history, to which Morris would subsequently give his allegiance, [...] instead it is akin to what Nietzsche would later call a yea-saying, in this case one in which the world, with all its good and ill, its foul and fair, is perceived and affirmed in a narrative

⁴ Felce, *William Morris and the Icelandic Sagas*, 2.

⁵ Morris, *The Story of Sigurd and the Fall of the Nibelungs*, 24.

that is forever repeated and renewed.”⁶ The image of *ragnarøk* came to inform Morris’s view of socialist revolution, emphasizing its violence and inevitability, while also framing it not in a historiographical narrative of progress, but in one of tragedy and struggle. But for all the tragedy and violence Morris found in medieval Icelandic literature, he also found in Commonwealth Iceland the possibility for freedom and unalienated labor. Morris was not a utopian socialist but saw in the sagas the ability for common people to find meaning in not just heroic struggles and suffering, but also mundane agricultural labor. The Revolution may never arrive, but for Morris, the closest thing was Commonwealth Iceland.

Despite the romantic idealization of medieval Iceland we find in Morris’s writing, Morris was a very practical, hands-on figure. In addition to his literary production, Morris is perhaps best remembered for textiles, prints, and involvement in the British Arts and Crafts Movement, a reaction against the increasing alienation of labor in a rapidly industrializing Britain.⁷ Fundamentally, Morris saw in the figure of the free Icelandic farmer the possibility for a society based upon unalienated labor. In Marxist thought, labor is the fundamental struggle with nature to reproduce the conditions of one’s own subsistence. When an individual spends their labor-power shaping their environment to their will, the product of their labor is in a very real sense a reflection of their inner being. The worker is thus in some sense identical with or connected to their work. Marx imagined a distant past in which labor was unalienated in this way, but increasingly under the capitalist mode of production, labor and its fruits came to confront the worker as something that no longer belonged to him or her:

⁶ Ashurst, “William Morris and the Volsungs,” 59.

⁷ *ibid.*

[T]he external character of labor for the worker appears in the fact that it is not his own, but someone else's, that it does not belong to him, that in it he belongs, not to himself, but to another. Just as in religion the spontaneous activity of the human imagination, of the human brain and the human heart, operates on the individual independently of him – that is, operates as an alien, divine or diabolical activity – so is the worker's activity not his spontaneous activity. It belongs to another; it is the loss of his self. As a result, therefore, man (the worker) only feels himself freely active in his animal functions—eating, drinking, procreating, or at most in his dwelling and in dressing-up, etc.; and in his human functions he no longer feels himself to be anything but an animal. What is animal becomes human, and what is human becomes animal.⁸

The possibility of unalienated labor in an industrialized Europe became a central concern for Morris. His theory of alienated and unalienated labor is best expressed in his manifesto, *Useful Work v. Useless Toil*, in which he argues for a world in which class is abolished and all are put to productive labor. And yet, Morris's vision for the future is far from a globe-spanning workhouse. Instead, given the waste, contradictions, and parasitism inherent to industrial capitalism, if all were put to productive work and no labor-power wasted, "such a holiday our lives might be."⁹ His future society is a world in which a "man might easily learn and practice at least three crafts, varying sedentary occupation with outdoor-occupation calling for the exercise of strong bodily energy for work in which the mind had more to do."¹⁰ If this were the extent of Morris's thinking, then he may have been remembered as merely one more 19th century utopian socialist. But what is unique in his writing, and the reason why I begin this study with a consideration of his work, is the absolutely central role that an imagined North played in his political and aesthetic thinking. Morris's interest in the sagas was not relegated to his artistic translations, but also heavily inspired his theoretical writings. As Felce

⁸ Marx, "Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts of 1844," 74.

⁹ Morris, *Useful Work v. Useless Toil*, 14.

¹⁰ *ibid*, 19.

states, “[f]ar from being an incidental pastime, Morris’s engagement with Old Norse literature was a crucial element in the development of his thought and the later passions on which much of his legacy rests.”¹¹ For Morris, medieval Iceland was not just a society of free men struggling against a harsh environment, but also a society of craftsmen and poets. It is no surprise then that these representations of Commonwealth Iceland became so meaningful for him, embodying as he thought they did the possibility for a society founded on unalienated labor which was also artistically productive.

The Historiographical Tradition of The Free Viking Peasant

William Morris was certainly not the first to project political notions of liberty onto the Northern past. Already in the 2nd century CE, Tacitus’ writings in *Germania* romanticized the uncorrupt and virile men of the North as role models for a Roman Republic sliding into decadence. We see in *Germania*, for instance, an emphasis on the supposed purity of the Germanic peoples: “[T]he peoples of Germania have never been tainted by intermarriage with other nations, and stand out as a race distinctive, pure and unique of its kind.”¹² But this interest in the North as a site of liberty and purity has not been limited to merely rightwing and reactionary interpretations. According to scholar Julia Zernack,

two dominant schools of interpretation can be distinguished: the older of the two connects the peoples of the North or the Germanic peoples respectively to the idea of political freedom, has recourse to Tacitus and Montesquieu and uses the Old Norse material in particular to symbolize aspirations to liberty; the other evokes the Germanic peoples’ impulse for expansion during the Migration

¹¹ Felce, *William Morris and the Icelandic Sagas*, 2.

¹² Tacitus, *Germania*, 76.

Period with the obvious intention to legitimize contemporary claims for power or territory by establishing supposedly ancient rights.¹³

It is to this first, liberal strain in the reception history of medieval Icelandic literature that Morris's work properly belongs. Indeed, contemporary political developments have rightfully revived a scholarly interest in this secondary, more nationalist and reactionary strain of the reception,¹⁴ but as I will contend, it is the myths of the liberal reception history that have quietly lived on in the scholarship, influencing how we conceive of labor and liberty in medieval Iceland still to this day.

The modern reception history of the North can be traced back to the late 18th and early 19th centuries, with historical studies such as Erik Geijer's 1825 work, *Svea rikes häfder*. Much of the early scholarship of social history in Scandinavia is marked by what we might call the myth of the "free Viking peasant," which stressed the relative autonomy of the Northern farmer vis-à-vis his continental counterparts. Tyge Rothe (1781) and C.F. Allen (1840) even go so far as to claim that there was no aristocracy in Scandinavia during the Viking Age.¹⁵ Later scholarship, such as Kristian Erslev's 1900 work, *Danmarks Riges Historie*, also alleged a fundamentally democratic society in the Scandinavian Middle Ages, the aristocracy supposedly developing later. To a large extent, these early historiographical studies of Scandinavia can be said to recapitulate the worldview of the saga writers themselves, as they took for granted that the migration from Norway to Iceland took place in response to the loss of traditional freedoms, and that the settlement of Iceland was fundamentally a project to preserve these ancestral

¹³ Zernack, "Old Norse Mythology and Heroic Legend in Politics, Ideology, and Propaganda," 475. In *The Pre-Christian Religions of the North*.

¹⁴ See: von Schnurbein, *Norse Revival: Transformations of Germanic Neopaganism* for the recent re-politicizations of Germanic and Old Norse symbolism.

¹⁵ Poulsen and Sindbæk, "Settlement and Lordship in Viking and Early Medieval Scandinavia," 4.

freedoms.¹⁶ This historiographical tradition of the free Viking peasant is linked to the rise of the modern Scandinavian states, and it is clear that their interpretation of the social history of medieval Scandinavia said just as much about their aspirations and desires for society as it did about the historical reality. Recently, through anthropological and archaeological scholarship, a new consensus has emerged which has redefined the role of hierarchy in social development, placing greater emphasis on an emerging nobility and the focalization of symbolic power in “central places,” such as the Lejre hall.¹⁷ A common view in the scholarship is now one of “a great transformation in the late tenth and eleventh century, which replaced a pagan society of mostly free peasants with church, taxation, stationary villages and estates, together with a new agrarian regime focused on common field cultivation of cereal crops.”¹⁸ Given this reception history, it is easy to see how for someone like Morris, the medieval North became a prelapsarian paradise, where farmers worked for themselves and ruggedly resisted domination.

However, the romanticization of medieval Iceland does not merely belong to the past. Nor does it merely belong to rightwing fringes. Ross Samson, for instance, has pointed out how the liberal historiographical tradition has represented chieftains as selfless, elected parliamentarians, who rationally pursued justice for the peaceful progress of a prosperous people.¹⁹ Most modern scholars would of course reject such a simplistic view, and yet, there are subtle ways in which this myth still lives on. Samson highlights how in Jón Jóhannesson’s very influential 1974 study, *History of the Old*

¹⁶ Wickham, “Passages to Feudalism in Medieval Scandinavia,” 143.

¹⁷ Christensen: “Lejre Beyond Legend: The Archaeological Evidence.” *Journal of Danish Archaeology*, 10.

¹⁸ Poulsen and Sindbæk, “Settlement and Lordship in Viking and Early Medieval Scandinavia,” 7.

¹⁹ Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” 168. In *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*. Gísli Pálsson, ed.

Icelandic Commonwealth, he claims that the position of *goði* cannot have been very lucrative and that their social role must therefore have been rather limited.²⁰ By isolating the role of *goði* into merely a legal office that brought with it certain rights and obligations, other forms of “soft power,” such as cultural and social capital are ignored. This proves to be the great weakness of the liberal historiographical approach to medieval Icelandic society—it tends to focus on legal categories and the *formal* rights and equality enjoyed by medieval Icelanders, to the exclusion of other sources of wealth, power, and coercion over others. Samson also implicates the work of American scholars Jesse Byock and William Miller in this tradition, both of whom have claimed that thing- and temple-taxes never constituted significant sources of wealth, thereby downplaying the exploitative nature of the chieftain-client relationship.²¹ The Icelandic Commonwealth may have begun as a recognizably egalitarian political project, but by the *Sturlungaöld*, real power was only wielded by a handful of families in Iceland. The libertarian fantasy in time yielded to its inevitable conclusion: feudalism, as the constitution of the Commonwealth was by design unable to protect the liberties it enshrined.²² It is perhaps then no surprise that scholars such as David Friedman, the son of Milton Friedman, have become interested in medieval Iceland as a model anarcho-capitalist society.²³ And yet, despite the harms of such myths as the free Viking peasant,

²⁰ cf. Jón Jóhannesson, *History of the Old Icelandic Commonwealth*. Haraldur Bessason, trans. “[T]he office of a chieftain does not appear to have been a lucrative position, considering the many expenses involved. Historical records contain many references to chieftains in the 11th and the 12th centuries who were in straitened circumstances. It has thus been suggested that these men were faced with diminished income when payments of the temple-tolls were suspended.” 62

²¹ Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” 169. In *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*.

²² Meulengracht Sørensen, “Social Institutions and Belief Systems of Medieval Iceland and Their Relations to Literary Production.” 24. In *Old Icelandic Literature and Society*.

²³ cf. Friedman, “Private Creation and Enforcement of Law: A Historical Case.”

we nevertheless find more “peasant autonomy” in both literary and historical sources of the North than we might reasonably expect from the continent.²⁴ It is a common attitude in the Icelandic sagas, for instance, that aristocratic dominance is not taken for granted. Hierarchy was something that existed in Norway perhaps, but not “here” at home in Iceland for a medieval saga writer.

Medieval Mentalities and Labor in a Broader Perspective

Looking back upon the reception of theories of labor and political liberty in the medieval North, it becomes clear the attempt to reconstruct an original and monolithic saga worldview becomes fraught rather quickly. In his reflection on the comparative method, Jens Peter Schjødt provocatively states that such attempts are ultimately fruitless: “No religion has ever existed in a ‘pure’ form, unpolluted by other religions and world views. There may be intense syncretism in different areas and periods, whereas in others it is hardly possible to register; but it is always there.”²⁵ Our interest here relates to labor and social relations, but the implication is clear: what may appear as a stabile system is merely a diachronic snapshot, shot through with residues of history and foreign borrowing. Perhaps more provocatively, Schjødt claims that it is neither desirable nor possible to reconstruct a medieval Northern worldview using only sources from the medieval North.²⁶ In what follows, I briefly lay out a sketch of what might be called a dominant view of labor in the western European Middle Ages. The goal, in line with Schjødt, is not to reconstruct a purely Christian theory of labor and

²⁴ Wickham, “Passages to Feudalism in Medieval Scandinavia,” 143.

²⁵ Schjødt, “Reflections on Aims and Methods in the Study of Old Norse Religion,” 265. In *More than Mythology: Narratives, Ritual Practices and Regional Distribution in Pre-Christian Scandinavian Religions*. Raudvere and Schjødt, eds.

²⁶ *ibid*, 280.

then find it pristinely translated into the medieval Icelandic literature, nor to find the contradictions between the pre-Christian and Christian worldview. Instead, in viewing dominant contemporary representations of labor and identifying to what degree it is absent or present in medieval Icelandic literature, we form a useful analytic category which can bear better witness to the heterogeneity of attitudes that must surely have existed within medieval Iceland.

According to Aron Gurevich, the ancient Greeks viewed labor as something fundamentally beneath free men.²⁷ We see this, for instance, in the theory of natural slavery advanced by Aristotle, in which slaves were constructed as more embodied than the free citizens of Athens, and who, due to this greater embodiment, must labor in the fields.²⁸ The goal for a free citizen was to attend legal assemblies, take part in athletic compositions, cultivate his artistic sensibility, perform public religious rites, and feast with his friends—in other words, self-realization for the Greeks was something that took place outside the realm of material production.²⁹ For the pre-Christian, aristocratic mind, labor and the higher goods in life were fundamentally at odds with one another. Christianity, in Gurevich's account, broke radically with ancient attitudes towards labor. With the collapse of the mercantile civilization of the Mediterranean in late antiquity, the sphere of liberty that had been carved out by the slave economies of Greece and Rome contracted, and it became increasingly difficult for the societies characterized by small-scale production in the early Middle Ages to view labor with this aristocratic disdain. Through the influence of Christianity and the changing social relations of late

²⁷ Gurevich, *Categories of Medieval Culture*. 212.

²⁸ Aristotle, *Politics*, 5-6.

²⁹ Gurevich, *Categories of Medieval Culture*. 213.

antiquity and the early Middle Ages, labor acquired a moral dimension, associated with the Fall out of Eden and original sin. However, unlike what Weber would describe as the Protestant work ethic, which saw earthly success as *signs* of salvation, the theological goal of labor in the medieval period is fundamentally the production of what is *necessary*. As Le Goff states, “[t]he aim of work was not economic progress, whether individual or collective. It had religious and moral ends such as avoiding idleness, which left the door open for the devil, doing penance through toil, or humiliating the body, and its economic aims were ensuring one’s own subsistence and that of the poor who were unable to procure their own property.”³⁰ However, this shift was not a complete replacement, and we see aspects of the pre-Christian aristocratic ethos still operative in the worldview of both the Christian Middle Ages in general, and also the world of the medieval Icelandic sagas. The aristocratic-warrior ethos can be seen as a residue, existing alongside the increasingly dominant Christian view of labor. Nevertheless, the Christian conception of labor was not monolithic and the changes in social relations that accompanied the collapse of the classical world led to contradictions in how labor was represented in medieval Europe. As we have stated, the aristocratic disdain for the laboring classes became increasingly difficult to fully maintain in the face of the contracting sphere of freedom left to the aristocracy following the collapse of the Roman slave system. In the new, Christian, understanding of labor, there was at least theoretically a moral and ethical value to agricultural labor. This led to many contradictions in the medieval mind regarding labor, and Paul

³⁰ Le Goff, *Medieval Civilization*, 222.

Friedman has outlined the many ways in which images of the rustic simultaneously cast them as marginal and peripheral, pious and base.³¹

To date, there has been a wealth of scholarship on the social history of saga-age Iceland, from its settlement to its loss of independence under Norway in 1262-4. As we have noted, a main current in the scholarship has highlighted the fundamentally egalitarian nature of Commonwealth Iceland, and how it was only under the foreign influence of Norway that the “free peasant” society was disrupted, and hierarchy introduced.³² However, as Orning states, one of the reasons why this view has been so persistent in the scholarship is the privileged position of legal sources, with sagas being seen as too subjective, private, and unreliable.³³ This view has been complicated in more recent scholarship, with the sagas becoming an increasingly legitimate source for contemporary worldviews.³⁴ Jón Viðar Sigurðsson has made significant contributions to our understanding of saga-age social structures by his analysis of patron-client relationships, developing the concept of “vertical friendship,” which has called into question both past narratives of egalitarianism, and also narratives of Iceland as a kin-based society.³⁵ Another important current in the scholarship has been the place of Marx and to what extent a Marxist framework can be helpful in interpreting medieval Icelandic society. Knut Helle’s 1964 *Norge blir en stat 1130–1319* has been a landmark in the field, arguing against a Marxist account of state formation, and instead for a model in which the monarchy was not an instrument of the landed classes, but as a

³¹ Freedman, *Images of the Medieval Peasant*, 12.

³² Orning, “Class,” 319. In *The Routledge Research Companion to the Medieval Icelandic Sagas*.

³³ *ibid*, 320.

³⁴ cf. Sverrir Jakobsson’s 2007 article: “Hauksbók and the Construction of an Icelandic World View.” *Saga-Book* 31.

³⁵ Jón Viðar Sigurðsson, *Chieftains and Power*. 92-3.

way for peasants to protect themselves against local nobility. In doing so, he has de-emphasized the role of class in the Norwegian civil war, while emphasizing the role of horizontal organizational structures.³⁶ Nevertheless, for both Knut Helle and Sverre Bagge, class remains an important frame for understanding medieval Norway and Iceland. Recently, Torfi Tulinius has given more weight to Marxist social theory with regard to the strengthening of a chieftain class through an analysis of the legendary sagas. In his account, Icelandic literary production came in large part out of the need for the *goðar* to construct a class identity for themselves and to more strongly differentiate themselves against the peasantry.³⁷ In a later work, he draws on the social theory of Pierre Bourdieu, whose work on social distinction has employed Marxist categories of class to account for taste and class identity structured around cultural, social, and economic capital.³⁸ And yet, despite these promising directions in the scholarship, I perceive a lack. There has, to date, been no sustained literary study which takes as its object the medieval Icelandic attitude towards labor itself as represented in the sagas. Richard Cole has made recent and interesting contributions in this direction,³⁹ but I believe the field is both open and productive.

The Task at Hand

We have briefly considered what the medieval Icelandic farmer meant to romantics such as William Morris, and the place of the “free Viking peasant” more broadly in the historiographical tradition. The medieval Icelandic peasant has come to

³⁶ For a summary of this argument, see Helle, “The Norwegian kingdom: succession, disputes and consolidation.” In *Cambridge History of Scandinavia*, vol 1. 369-76.

³⁷ Torfi Tulinius, *The Matter of the North*, 290 –1.

³⁸ Torfi Tulinius, *The Enigma of Egill*, 167–9.

³⁹ See: Cole, “Homotopia, or, Reading Sagas on an Industrial Estate.”

mean much for others, but I would like to now ask the question: what might labor have meant for medieval Icelanders, the writers and audience of the sagas? What did it mean for a medieval Icelandic to toil in the field, day in, day out? Was it a curse, or was there dignity in working the land? Whose labor was counted as valuable, and whose labor less so? Who had to labor, and who enjoyed cultivation, leisure, and liberty at the expense of others? In medieval Iceland, wealth was fundamentally created by working the land, in addition to fishing and some limited trading. But, as Samson states, “land is not in and of itself wealth. It generates wealth largely through the labor of people. The key to understanding the nature of the power and wealth of *goðar* is to be found in the ways *goðar* controlled or exploited the wealth generated by others.”⁴⁰ As we shall see, it is very difficult to get a direct look at labor in the sagas, and in considering labor, we must immediately begin to consider social relations more broadly. As such, this study will divide Icelandic society into *goðar*, slaves, and the amorphous group of freemen who found themselves between these two socio-economic extremes. It goes without saying that the labor of women was of critical importance on the Icelandic farmstead.

Noteworthy recent scholarship on women in medieval Iceland includes Jenny Jochens’ 1995 book, *Women in Old Norse Society* and Jóhanna Katrín Friðriksdóttir’s 2013 work, *Women in Old Norse Literature: Bodies, Words, and Power*, both of which place an emphasis on the labor of women and the ways in which it was rendered less visible than the labor of men. When we limit the extent of this project it is for reasons of economy, knowing full well that a complete account of women’s labor in medieval Iceland would be as significant an undertaking, if not more so, than the project which

⁴⁰ Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” 172-3. In *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*. Gísli Pálsson, ed.

lies before the reader. I shall focus on that group of sagas called the sagas of the Icelanders, given their broad interest in not just feuding and adventuring, but also their historical consciousness and interest in Icelandic society. As we shall see, the social reality of labor in medieval Iceland was far from a utopian vision of unalienated labor. Indeed, I contend that one of the primary sources of the sagas' historical self-consciousness is due to the increasingly alienated nature of labor in the transition from a free-farmer society to a rent-based tenant system. And yet, despite the dangers of the liberal romanticization of the Icelandic Commonwealth, there is nevertheless a meaningful way in which a medieval Icelandic peasant was freer than his or her peers on the continent. The task I set out for myself here is not to inquire into the historical reality of these conditions, but rather to ask how they were thought of by the saga authors, and possibly their audience. Far from one monolithic attitude (or one dominant class interest), we instead see a multitude of attitudes, which do not merely correspond to class interest. Medieval Iceland seems to have had just as many attitudes towards labor as we do today.

2. The Representation of Slave Labor

The slave (*þræll*) is a well-attested figure in both medieval Icelandic literature and historical sources, such as the *Grágás* law codes. Slavery was present in Iceland from the beginning of its settlement, with both *Landnámabók* and several sagas giving accounts of Viking raids in Scotland and Ireland and bringing these slaves home to Iceland.⁴¹ The true extent of slavery in medieval Iceland is unknown, although it seems a common enough practice from the literary and legal sources. In Norway, the *Frostaping* laws describe a normal peasant household as consisting of twelve cows, two horses, and three slaves,⁴² and Stefan Brink has estimated a quarter of the population as a theoretical maximum for slavery in Iceland.⁴³ Over time, slavery became less economically significant and although it was never formally abolished, the practice likely disappeared in the 12th century, and certainly by the 13th.⁴⁴ It has been suggested that slavery began to wane as Viking activity in Western Europe declined. It may have also been the case that if the system were economically advantageous, that a hereditary slave class could have still existed in Iceland. However, scholars have argued that as a class of free, unlanded laborers began to grow in the generations after Icelandic settlement, that it became preferable for landowners to hire laborers on a seasonal basis, or else rent land to tenants, with former slaves and freedmen forming a key part of this new cottager class.⁴⁵ Slavery is of particular interest to us because it was the most fundamental legal distinction in the medieval Icelandic law codes. We have literary and

⁴¹ Karras, "Slavery," 598. In *The Routledge Encyclopedia of Medieval Scandinavia*.

⁴² Orning, "Class," 307.

⁴³ Brink, "Slavery in the Viking Age," 49. In *The Viking World*.

⁴⁴ Miller, *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking*, 28.

⁴⁵ Karras, "Slavery," 599. In *The Routledge Encyclopedia of Medieval Scandinavia*.

historical evidence for a broad diversity in social stratification, but as far as *Grágás* was concerned, there were formally only two classes in Iceland: free and unfree.⁴⁶ Slaves had virtually no rights under the law, being treated practically as livestock. They could be bought and sold, and the slaying of slaves was compensated to their owner, not to the slave's kin. One of the few protections enjoyed by slaves was that after manumission, the former owner could still be responsible for paying maintenance to the freedman or his children.⁴⁷ However, given the scale of Icelandic agriculture, medieval Icelandic slaves likely were given the same labor as members of the household, although we might assume that the less desirable tasks were often reserved for them.⁴⁸

Regarding the literary representation of slaves, Stefan Brink has claimed: "In the sagas the thrall is always a stereotype—dark, short and stupid, no doubt used as spice in the narrative to contrast with the blond, tall and wise hero."⁴⁹ As we shall see, this is largely true. There are some exceptional cases of good and virtuous slaves, but this generally entails physical strength and obedience. This stereotyping of the slave also often reverses the cause and effect of the degradation of the slave; instead of seeing this figure as pitiable and exploited, we instead see a justification that takes the abject state of the slave as a reason for their social position: "Particular duties or legal disabilities are assigned to the slave because of his or her enslavement, but contemporaries may see the causal relationship the other way around, particular kinds of work or particular legal disabilities giving rise to particular moral or personal qualities perceived as justifying enslavement."⁵⁰ A good slave, we might say, had the same virtues as a well-grown ox or

⁴⁶ Miller, *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking*, 26.

⁴⁷ Vilhjálmur Finsen, ed. *Grágás: Konungsbók*, §112.

⁴⁸ Karras, "Slavery," 599. In *The Routledge Encyclopedia of Medieval Scandinavia*.

⁴⁹ Brink, "Slavery in the Viking Age," 49. In *The Viking World*.

⁵⁰ Karras, *Slavery and Society in Medieval Scandinavia*, 40.

horse, and we see in the sagas a fascination with the body of the slave. This is especially evident in *Rígsþula*, one of our main sources for class, hierarchy, and worldview in medieval Iceland. *Rígsþula* is an Eddic poem which is found in fragmented form in the *Codex Wormianus*, AM 242 fol, a medieval Icelandic manuscript from the mid-14th century.⁵¹ The poem details the travels of the god Heimdallr, who, under the alias of *Rígr*, visits three farmsteads and enjoys the hospitality of his hosts. Heimdallr sleeps in the bed of his hosts for three nights each and sires children who become the originators of the social classes. At the first farmstead, he sires the child *Þræl*, who goes on to have such children as Noisy, Smelly, and, among others, Fatty.⁵² This thrall-class is described as physically repulsive: “Hann nam að vaxa / og vel dafna. / Var þar á höndum / hrökkið skinn, / kroppnir knúar, / fingur digrir, / fúllegt andlit, / lotur hryggur, / langir hælir.”⁵³ The thralls are also associated with dark skin, “armur sólbrunninn,”⁵⁴ potentially a reference to agricultural labor.⁵⁵ The dating of *Rígsþula* is problematic. Scholars as different as Andreas Heusler and Mazo Karras have argued for a later date of the poem, the former on the basis of intellectual history,⁵⁶ and the latter for socio-historical reasons:

The poem does not reflect Icelandic social structure at all, nor does it reflect the social structure in Norway much before the thirteenth century. A poem is more likely to depict a social class that is no longer significant, as was the case with slaves in the thirteenth century, than one that is not yet significant, as with nobility in the ninth. Norway did have kings, [...] [b]ut a noble class, as distinct

⁵¹ Simek, *Dictionary of Northern Mythology*, 264.

⁵² The full list of names reads as such: “Hreimur og Fjósniir, / Klúr og Kleggi, / Kefsir, Fúlnir, / Drumbur, Digraldi, / Dröttur og Hösvir, / Lútur og Leggjalði.” Ólafur Briem, ed. “*Rígsþula*,” 305. In *Eddukvæði II*.

⁵³ *ibid.*

⁵⁴ *ibid.*

⁵⁵ Dronke, however, points to an interesting connection with color and caste ideology in India. “Eddic poetry,” 674. See Freedman on depictions of peasants in a broader, continental context. *Images of the Medieval Peasant*, 15-39.

⁵⁶ Heusler. “Heimat und Alter der eddischen Gedichte,” 273.

from free men as free men were from slaves, probably was not an important factor in Norwegian society during the Viking Age.⁵⁷

There are, however, reasons to believe in an earlier date of the poem, placing it perhaps in the Viking Age, and potentially in an even further, Germanic past. Ursula Dronke has argued this from a philological perspective, claiming that the poem “gives us the closest view we shall ever get of the paths of religious thought among the Germanic people.”⁵⁸ This question cannot be resolved here, but given an earlier date, we do potentially have a glimpse into an “authentic,” or rather early, view of social organization in the Viking Age. Given a later date, we may find that the poem forms a later justification for then-emerging social dynamics. Nevertheless, what we can state with certainty, and the object of this section, is that the slave in medieval Icelandic literature is represented as being more embodied than others. They are given to base instincts, and are often ugly, physically misshapen, petty, and cruel. A slave, it was assumed, had at some point forfeited their right to life, either by being captured in battle, surrendering, or otherwise losing their rights. Stefan Brink describes the logic of slaveholding, not just in the medieval North, but throughout history, as follows:

[A] man who was defeated and caught in war and not slaughtered had given up his right to live [...] In war all defeated men not killed in battle should be slaughtered afterwards; that was the custom not only in ancient Europe, but also among North American Indians and other people. If their life were spared, they had forfeited their right to be free. They had been given a gift, their life, but had to pay back by giving up their freedom, the right of being looked upon as a human being; instead they became a tool for their master.⁵⁹

Seen in this way, the slave is a body that has already died, and this notion of “social death” has often been used by scholars to describe the legal and symbolic position of the

⁵⁷ Karras, *Slavery and Society in Medieval Scandinavia*. 61-2.

⁵⁸ Dronke, “Eddic poetry as a source for the history of Germanic religion,” 667.

⁵⁹ Brink, *Slavery in the Viking Age*, 50.

slave.⁶⁰ We might say that in a dualistic view of body and soul, lower and higher self, that a slave is left only with the former. What we are left with is a figure that is reduced to a mere body, excluded from the higher domains of freedom, politics, and rights.

In considering the figure of the slave, I draw on the writings of Giorgio Agamben, whose work on biopolitics has traced many of the threads we consider here to the beginnings of Western intellectual history. For Agamben, power has ultimately always had the body as its object, and the political as such can be best understood when seen as a form of control over the body. Agamben's field of interest has generally concerned ancient Mediterranean societies, in addition to the beginnings of Absolutism in France and Western Europe, but many of Agamben's categories can also be deployed in the medieval North in an enlightening way. A fundamental distinction for Agamben is that between *bios* and *zoē*. Both are terms that the Greeks associated with life, but where *bios* denoted the "form or way of living proper to an individual or group,"⁶¹ *zoē* referred to only the "simple fact of living common to all beings."⁶² *Bios* is a higher level of existence, and when the Greeks spoke of the way of life proper to the free citizens of Athens, it was denoted by *bios*. *Zoē*, however, is shared in common with all living beings, from citizens to slaves and animals. In Agamben's account, the history of politics has been a history of power over the body, and this power often manifests in regulating the boundary of exclusion between *bios* and *zoē*—in other words, who participates in communication and political activity, and who is reduced to a mere, biological body, and thereby relegated to the realm of material production. The

⁶⁰ cf. Patterson, *Slavery and Social Death*.

⁶¹ Agamben, *Homo Sacer*, 1.

⁶² *ibid.*

paradigmatic figure that Agamben takes up in his biopolitical investigations is that of *homo sacer*, a legal category from Roman Law:

The term *homo sacer* itself once referred, in ancient Rome, to a person excommunicated from society, removed from the safeguards offered to its normal members so that his biological life subsequently could be taken by anyone with impunity. It meant [...] that normal political rights and legal safeguards were stripped away, so that the *homo sacer* was reduced to the mere naked, or bare, life.⁶³

For Agamben, *homo sacer* is the category which serves as the foundation of sovereign power, which is always threatening to turn its own citizens into rightless bodies.

However, Magnus Fiskesjö has rightfully pointed out the marked absence of slaves in Agamben's thinking, who were not under threat of being turned into "mere bodies," but instead constantly lived in this condition. Indeed, slavery found its most forceful justifications in the same pages of Aristotle which Agamben also cites in his exploration of these same categories.⁶⁴ The broader implications of this debate are of course beyond the bounds of our consideration here. What we can take from a broadly biopolitical framework, however, does reveal a potentially new way of considering labor, especially that of slaves in medieval Iceland, and we see how slaves are often portrayed as not fully human, determined more by their biology than the other agents of the narrative.⁶⁵

The Lazy Slave

In examining how the labor of slaves is represented, we might also consider how it is *not* represented in the sagas. That is, we find a common trope throughout many of

⁶³ Fiskesjö, "Outlaws, barbarians, slaves: critical reflections on Agamben's *Homo sacer*," 162.

⁶⁴ *ibid.*

⁶⁵ Slaves are often also represented as shape-shifters. Jón Hnefill Aðalsteinsson considers this trope in the context of *Geirmundar þáttur heljarskinns* of *Sturlunga saga*, where the slave Atli is said to be a shape-shifter. "The Position of Freed Slaves in Medieval Iceland." *Saga-Book* 22 (1986-9).

the sagas of Icelanders of the lazy slave. In *Brennu-Njáls saga*, for instance, we find the slave Melkólfr, an Irishman.⁶⁶ He originally belongs to one Hallbjörn hvíti, the brother of both Otkell and Hallkell. He expresses the wish to be owned instead by Otkell, who treats him generously and gives him gifts: “Otkell var vel til hans ok gaf honum kníf ok belt ok alklæðnað, en þrællinn vann allt þat, er hann vildi.”⁶⁷ However, his cooperation and goodwill toward his new master turn out to be a ruse. In effect, Melkólfr “courts” his new master through deception, but once he is in Otkell’s household, he becomes much less cooperative: “En þegar er Otkell átti þrællinn, þá vann hann allt verr. Otkell ræddi um opt fyrir Hallbirni hvíta, at honum þótti þrællinn lítit vinna; hann segir honum þó annat verr gefit.”⁶⁸ Of course, Hallbjörn’s prediction will turn out to be correct, as Gunnarr is unable to buy provisions from Otkell, but buys the troublesome slave from him instead. Melkólfr then, under the instructions of Hallgerðr, will steal from the farmstead at Kirkjubær and instigate a series of conflicts that will ultimately weaken Gunnarr. Melkólfr, then, is quite simply to be seen as morally deplorable. With regard to visual depictions of Anglo-Saxon slaves, David Pelteret has emphasized this moralizing as a defense mechanism for the institution of slavery: “Students of more modern forms of slavery will recognize the same defensiveness with which slavery is justified: slaves are described in physical terms that are considered ugly by the dominant culture and as having a deplorable moral character.”⁶⁹ We see this in a general sense throughout the sagas, as we have noted especially in *Rígsþula*, but there is some

⁶⁶ Notably, when he is first introduced he is also said to be *óvinsæll*, unpopular or without friends. Jón Hnefill Aðalsteinsson also discusses the trope of the antisocial slave in “The Position of Freed Slaves in Medieval Iceland.” *Saga-Book* 22 (1986-9).

⁶⁷ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Brennu-Njáls saga*, §47.

⁶⁸ *ibid.*

⁶⁹ Pelteret, “The Image of the Slave in Some Anglo-Saxon and Norse Sources,” 82.

particular irony in the accusation of laziness in a slave. For the exploiter who owns the totality of a laborer's power to accuse them of laziness, and to use a modern term, of wage-theft, is of course distasteful. We might, however, remember that the scale of medieval Icelandic slavery was rather limited. Instead of working in labor gangs on agricultural plantations, Scandinavian slaves "mingled freely with their masters."⁷⁰ Occasionally, this proximity could breed paternalism on behalf of the master and loyalty on behalf of the slave, but there must also have been resistance: "[B]ut in slave societies where the masters claimed to have this kind of loyalty the slaves still resented their masters and resisted their control in many ways, from sloppy work and pilfering to outright revolt. The stereotype in Icelandic literature of the lazy slave could derive from such a deliberate refusal to work zealously in the master's interests."⁷¹ The trope of the lazy slave addresses a very deep fear in the medieval Icelandic mind, and it is no coincidence that the one virtue a slave could fulfill, to be strong and productive, is inverted into this trope. Seen biopolitically, the body of the slave is expected to only participate in material production, and the one act of resistance left to an Icelandic slave was to deny their master the products of their labor. Beyond the fear of a disobedient slave, however, what may have been truly frightening for the saga writer is the idea of an unproductive body on an Icelandic farmstead, given the harsh material conditions of medieval Icelandic agriculture.

⁷⁰ Karras, *Slavery and Society in Medieval Scandinavia*, 123.

⁷¹ *ibid.*

The Stupid and Cowardly Slave

Just as slaves are often represented as being particularly lazy, another very common trope we find in the sagas is that of the stupid and cowardly slave, which I also read as being part of the larger, biopolitical construction of the slave as more embodied, potentially more animal, than his or her master. We find several interesting exemplars of this trope in *Eyrbyggja saga*. We see, for instance, how slaves, following the freeman Nagli, fall to their death after running away in Chapter 18 of *Eyrbyggja saga*:

[T]óku þeir nú rás af nýju allir inn til hofðans ok runnu þar til, er þeir koma þar, sem nú heitir Þrælaskriða; þar fengu þeir Þórarinn tekit Nagla, því at hann var nálíga sprunginn af mœði, en þrælarnir hljópu þar fyrir ofan ok fram af hofðanum ok týndum, sem ván var, því at hofðinn er svá hár, at allt hefir bana, þat er þar ferr ofan.⁷²

This scene perhaps serves a comic function, and we might imagine a saga audience laughing at the graphic misfortune of these slaves. The humor, if we might call it that, is twofold, in that it relies upon the notion of the slave as particularly cowardly, hence the flight from the battle, but also stupid enough to not notice a cliff. Of course, we might ask why a slave might be expected to fight, given that a slave stood completely outside the honor economy as described by William Miller.⁷³ Slaves fundamentally had no stake in honor, which was a system only those whose lives were constructed as *bios* participated in. All that was left to a slave was their mere, biological life, and so we might not blame a slave for striving to protect all he or she had.

One of the most puzzling and humorous representations of the slave comes later in *Eyrbyggja saga*, during the death of Arnkell. Like many slayings, this scene plays against the background of agricultural labor. Arnkell, we are told, is an industrious

⁷² Einar Sveinsson and Matthías Þórðarson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*, §18.

⁷³ Miller, *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking*, 26.

laborer who works his land thoroughly and intensely: “Arnkell var starfsmaðr mikill ok lét þræla sína vinna alla daga milli sólsetra.”⁷⁴ Indeed, Arnkell is so industrious that his slaves even work at night during the full moon, and there is a curious way in which the labor of his slaves stands in for his own industriousness.⁷⁵ During the haymaking, Arnkell is ambushed by a group of killers led by Snorri góði. As Arnkell notices the ambushers, he addresses his slaves: “Hér kann ek gott ráð til, því at hér skulu gera hvárir, þat er betra þykkir; þit skuluð hlaupa heim ok vekja upp fylgðarmenn mína, ok munu þeir koma skjótt til móts við mik, en hér er vígi gott í stakkgarðinum, ok mun ek heðan verjask, ef þetta eru ófriðarmenn, því at mér þykkir þat betra en renna.”⁷⁶ Here, at least initially, the slaves are not seen as being cowardly for not standing with their master and fighting. Rather, Arnkell implies that there are different activities appropriate to him as compared with them. His is the domain of honor and fighting, theirs is to seek help at the farmstead, again showing how slaves exist outside the economy of honor. What interests us is their behavior after being sent off by Arnkell, which we might describe as a state of temporary fear-induced madness. One slave runs off into the mountains, only to meet his end in a waterfall. The other hurries back to the farmstead, but immediately forgets his task and begins to help others with the haymaking. It is only the next morning, when Arnkell’s whereabouts are asked for, that he remembers his task: “Þá vöknudú fylgðarmenn Arnkels ok spurðu, hvar hann var. Þá var sem þrellinn vaknaði af svefni ok svarar: ‘Þat er satt,’ segir hann, ‘hann mun berjask inn á Örlygsstöðum við Snorra goða.’”⁷⁷ Hugo Gering has interpreted this scene

⁷⁴ Einar Sveinsson and Matthías Þórðarson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*, §37.

⁷⁵ Klaus Bödl refers to Arnkell as a “Symbolfigur bäuerlicher Prosperität”, or a symbolic figure of “formerly” prosperity. *Eigi einhamr*, 235.

⁷⁶ Einar Sveinsson and Matthías Þórðarson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*, §37.

⁷⁷ *ibid.*

as typical of the stupidity and cowardice of slaves in the sagas,⁷⁸ but this seemingly total amnesia is something different than mere stupidity or cowardice—indeed, given the way it is described as waking up, we might also ask whether the amnesia is induced by more supernatural means. As such, Klaus Bödl has interpreted the slaying of Arnkell as not merely a political killing, but rather as a fertility sacrifice as described by René Girard and J.G. Frazer based on the family association of prolific fertility and his unmarried status at the time of his killing.⁷⁹ Regardless of the true meaning of Arnkell's death, we can say that within the logic of the narrative, Arnkell's death follows directly from the failure of his slaves. These slaves fail in their task for different reasons, but both of their failures can ultimately be traced to their mental inferiority, which we might describe as childlike; the construction of the slaves in this way functions to exclude them from the category of *bios*, of a kind of life with freedom and political rights.

Paternalistic Slavery

In *Ólafs saga helga*, we find an account of one Erlingr, a prominent Norwegian noble. His wealth consists of large estates where he allows his slaves to work extra and thereby earn their freedom: “Erlingr hafði jafnan heima þrjá tigu þræla ok um fram annat man. Hann ætlaði þrælum sínum dagsverk ok gaf þeim stundir síðan ok lof til, at hvern, er sér vildi vinna um rökkr eða um nætr, hann gaf þeim akrloð at sá sér korni ok fœra ávøxtinn til fjár sér. Hann lagði á hvern þeira verð ok lausn.”⁸⁰ Notably, this forms one of the only representations of slavery at a large scale in medieval Scandinavia—the

⁷⁸ Gering, “Einleitung” in *Eyrbyggja saga* (1897), 137.

⁷⁹ Bödl, *Eigi einhamr*, 237.

⁸⁰ Bjarni Aðalbjarnarson, ed. *Heimskringla II*, §23.

literary representations in Iceland, given the smaller scale and more dispersed nature of agriculture, only present a picture of slaves as part of a small household.⁸¹ The law codes do provide ways for either a master to free a slave, or else for a slave to buy their freedom, but the situation at Erlingr's farm, whether or not it corresponds to a historical reality, is clearly supposed to stand out as noteworthy.⁸² Erlingr resembles here perhaps nothing so much as a modern, enlightened CEO, extracting wealth from his workforce while playing the role of the benevolent master. In emphasizing the benevolence of Erlingr, Snorri simultaneously downplays what cannot have been desirable conditions: "Leystu margir sik in fyrstu misseri eða önnur, en allir þeir, er nokkurr þrifnaðr var yfir, leystu sik á þrimr vetrum. Með því fé keypti Erlingr sér annat man, en leysingjum sínum vísaði hann sumum í síldfiski, en sumum til anarra fífanga. Sumir ruddu markir ok gerpu þar bú í. Öllum kom hann til nokkurs þroska."⁸³ Good slaves are able to free themselves quickly, and this is supposed to make their enslavement seem less brutal. Of course, *Heimskringla*'s perspective is fundamentally aristocratic. Sverre Bagge, in his *Society and Politics in Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla*, sees society broken into the traditional tripartite structure of king, magnates, and people, with the people largely seen as a homogenous mass without agency, led by the strong and influential.⁸⁴ Where slaves and freedmen do appear, they generally play no great role, especially in the political realm. This is significant as slaves were legally constructed as existing outside the law—as property, they belonged to the farmstead and thus the domestic sphere. In medieval Iceland, an important aspect of the manumission ceremony was entering the

⁸¹ Karras, *Slavery and Society in Medieval Scandinavia*, 78.

⁸² *ibid*, 128.

⁸³ Bjarni Aðalbjarnarson, ed. *Heimskringla II*, §23.

⁸⁴ Bagge, *Society and Politics*, 123.

legal community and transitioning from a private existence as property to a political and public subject. Jón Jóhannesson has stressed the symbolic nature of the manumission ceremony with an emphasis on manumission as entering the public sphere. Prior to manumission, a freedman was a *grefleysingr*, literally “one freed from digging,” and it was only after the public ceremony at a legal assembly that one was considered a true freedman.⁸⁵ Slaves are represented as being without agency, incapable of political action, and this view of slavery we have in *Heimskringla* is fundamentally a paternalistic one, dependent on the kind guidance of a generous master.

It is in light of these dynamics that I would like to suggest a way in which Erlingr’s slaves might nevertheless exercise some agency. During a time of shortage, it is forbidden to sell grain in Norway. One Ásbjörn, a kinsman of Erlingr, finds it increasingly difficult to provision his family, and he first goes to Þórir selr, the king’s *ármaðr*, to see whether he can buy grain from him. Interestingly, this royal official is said to be *ættsmár*, of low birth, perhaps suggesting a connection between royal service and slavery itself.⁸⁶ But Ásbjörn is unable to buy provisions and he carries on to his kinsman, the aforementioned Erlingr. Erlingr is aware of the ban on grain export as well but proposes a legal loophole. Ásbjörn can instead buy grain directly from his slaves, who do not fall under the same law as other men: “Þat þykki mér líkara, at þrælar mínir myni eiga korn, svá at þú munt vera fullkaupa. Þeir eru ekki í lögum eða landsrétt með qðrum mǫnnum.”⁸⁷ To be sure, this scene is not about the canny business-savvy of the slaves. The slaves instead are here to reaffirm the intelligent maneuvering of their social

⁸⁵ Jón Jóhannesson, *A History of the Old Icelandic Commonwealth*, 351.

⁸⁶ Bjarni Aðalbjarnarson, ed. *Heimskringla II*, §117.

⁸⁷ *ibid.*

superiors. They are not represented here as entrepreneurs, but rather as an offshore fund which falls outside the king's jurisdiction. What is supposedly more humane in Erlingr's system is that the slaves, in being left time to labor for themselves, are thus not entirely alienated from their labor as a slave often is. And yet the slaves, in selling their grain to Ásbjörn, are not presented as actors in a marketplace. We may assume it is desirable for these slaves to sell their grain, and thus be able to buy their manumission, but the context of this exchange still assumes an alienated relationship between the slaves and the products of their labor—it is as if the grain itself merely happens to fall under a separate legal category, allowing it to be sold. This exchange between Ásbjörn and Erlingr sows the seeds of further discord in the narrative. Upon returning, Þórir selr, the *ármaðr*, does not accept Ásbjörn's view on the legality of the grain and he confiscates the grain, sending Ásbjörn home to be shamed by his neighbors. The following year, Ásbjörn returns and slays Þórir selr in the presence of the king, and it is only the arrival of Erlingr with a large force of men that prevents his death. Ultimately, the conflict lays the foundations for further tensions in Norway, with relations between Ólafr and many of his magnates being permanently soured to the point that several, including Erlingr, side with Knútr when he claims the Norwegian throne. Sverre Bagge has written that in contrast to the ecclesiastical sagas and *Fagrskinna*, which stress the ideological reasons for Ólafr's downfall, including his strict sense of justice and his championing of Christianity, that Snorri emphasizes instead the fundamentally political nature of Ólafr's fall.⁸⁸ Is it possible that Erlingr's slaves serve as a very distant prime mover of Ólafr's fall, and thereby participate, if however tentatively, in the political

⁸⁸ Bagge, *Society and Politics*, 68.

realm? Perhaps for marginal figures who have no possibility for meaningful political action because of their exclusion from this category, disruption is the only way to exercise agency. Elsewhere, scholars have stressed the “disruptive” narrative role of other marginal figures, specifically women, with regard to the trope of whetting.⁸⁹ The figure of the “whetter,” personified best by Hallgerðr of *Brennu-Njáls saga*, goads men on to escalate feuds that might otherwise have reached a more peaceful resolution. As Jóhanna Katrín Friðriksdóttir describes the figure, “[w]hatever the narrator’s attitude to the whetting woman, and whatever her historicity, the figure is demonstrably active and powerful within the narrative.”⁹⁰ This is not to conflate two meaningfully distinct phenomena, but instead to suggest that in a system which does not allow for the participation of more marginal figures, disruption may be the only way for slaves and women to become a felt presence within the narrative. Erlingr’s slaves are certainly not conscious of themselves in this way, and the episode with the slaves takes up only a small portion of the greater narrative. Nevertheless, it is perhaps no coincidence that this participation of the slaves, however distantly, in the political economy has such negative consequences.

The Virtuous Slave

We do also have several accounts which view individual slaves positively. Very often these accounts concern slaves that physically resemble their masters, in both being strong but also Icelandic, and not, for instance, Celtic. In *Laxdæla saga*, we see an account of Þórðr, who owns the slave Ásgautr: “Þórðr átti þræl þann, er út kom með

⁸⁹ Jóhanna Katrín Friðriksdóttir, *Women in Old Norse Literature*, 21.

⁹⁰ *ibid.*

honum; sá hét Ásgautr. Hann var mikill maðr ok gerviligr, en þótt hann væri þræll kallaðr, þá máttu fáir taka hann til jafnaðarmanns við sik, þótt frjálsir hétu, ok vel kunni hann at þjóna sínum yfirmanni. Fleiri átti Þórðr þræla, þó at þessi sé einn nefndr.”⁹¹

Notably, the narrative makes a point of reminding us that of the many slaves owned by Þórðr, Ásgautr is the only who meaningfully stands out as an individual worth naming. The others belong to an unnamed, homogeneous mass. Ásgautr is furthermore said to accompany Þórðr from Norway, which along with his name tells us that Ásgautr is already in some sense more a part of the same community as his master than a foreign, nameless slave. Ásgautr is able to ultimately win his freedom by helping Þórofr escape, culminating in a daring crossing of an icy river. When he returns home, his deed is described as labor, and his manumission is implied to be his wage: “hefir þú nú Ásgautr [...] vel farit með þínu efni ok trúliga; skaltu nú ok vita skjótliga, til hvers þú hefir unnit; ek gef þér frelsi, svá at þú skalt frá þessum degi frjáls maðr heita.”⁹² Ultimately, he sails to Denmark to presumably become a successful farmer. Out of the so many other anonymous slaves who live and die miserably, how is Ásgautr represented to be more worthy than his peers? As another passage from *Eyrbyggja saga* will highlight, there is a sense in which not all slaves are slave, and that Ásgautr is really a free man who *happens* to be a slave.

In *Eyrbyggja saga*, we have an account of a farmer, Þorbrandr, who owns a slave, Egill: “Þorbrandr bóndi í Álptafirði átti þræl þann, er Egill sterki hét; hann var manna mestr ok sterkastr, ok þótti honum ill ævi sín, er hann var ánauðgaðr, ok bað opt Þorbrand ok sonu hans, at þeir gæfi honum frelsi, ok bauð þar til at vinna slíkt, er hann

⁹¹ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Laxdæla saga*, §11.

⁹² *ibid*, §16.

mætti.”⁹³ The first thing worth noting regarding this slave is clearly his physical strength, and it seems to be this characteristic, in addition to his native name, that introduce him into the narrative as a figure that will exert some agency, unlike many other slaves. Of course, because slaves are reduced to the merely biological aspects of life, a virtuous slave must by definition be a strong slave, with a body built to participate in material production. But there is also a way in which the body of Egill elevates him above his current social position. Just as *Rígsþula* presents the body of slaves as mirroring their already-determined social inferiority, the nobility are also presented as being innately more beautiful: “Svein ól Móðir, / silki vafði, / jósu vatni, / Jarl létu heita. / Bleikt var hár, / bjartir vangar, / ötul vóru augu / sem yrmlingi.”⁹⁴ We see here again the reverse logic of slavery—it is not the position of privilege that has allowed the aristocratic class to beautify themselves; instead, the physical is presented as a mere reflection of some innate superiority.⁹⁵ We might say that the saga worldview presents two possible figures of the slave—an eternal slave, whose social position is pre-determined by their inferiority, and a contingent slave, whose social position is only temporary. Egill clearly belongs to the latter group, of “spiritually” free men who happen to find themselves unfree. Perhaps just as equally that his body signifies his belonging to a different class of slave, he also retains the mentality of a free man, and he essentially enters into a contract for his freedom. There is a sense in this passage that Egill is still the owner of his labor power, and his awareness of this is what enables him to enter into a contract for his freedom. We might say that, despite his position of

⁹³ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*, §43.

⁹⁴ Ólafur Briem, ed. “*Rígsþula*,” 310-1. In *Eddukvæði II*.

⁹⁵ We might also think of the etymology of *aristocracy*—rule by the best.

exploitation, that Egill nevertheless retains an unalienated relationship to labor—it does not confront him as something external, but as the very essence of his freedom. Later, he is tasked with a slaying, but he sees an ill omen and his clumsiness leads to his capture by Björn. Notably, when asked to identify himself, he presents himself as a peer: “Egill er hér, Björn félagi.”⁹⁶ Ultimately, his journey is ill-fated, and he is executed by his captors. Although the story of Egill is clearly a vision of the “best possible” slave, we nevertheless see that even for an “inwardly free” slave, the state of slavery carried it with a constant threat. Again, we see a great emphasis placed on the body of the slave, but by retaining his ability to negotiate and by identifying freemen as his peers, Egill is not “merely” a body like so many other slaves. Instead, he retains an inner freedom, through his relationship to his labor, that he might have been able to barter into his manumission.

Section Conclusion

Just as there existed contradictory representations of the serf on the Continent,⁹⁷ we likewise see a plurality of images in medieval Icelandic literature that are often at odds with each other. On the Continent, we can broadly say that the position of the serf was justified in one of two ways: “For one, the peasant's condition could be regarded as merited punishment for some primordial sin [...] For another, if the peasant's essential nature fit him for little more than brutish, docile labor, if he were naturally lowly, dull, coarse, and stupid, then his labor and subordination could be viewed as simply

⁹⁶ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*, §43.

⁹⁷ Freedman, *Images of the Medieval Peasant*, 15.

appropriate, and no explanations based on sin or history would be needed.”⁹⁸ However, this aristocratic disdain within the context of the Three Orders of aristocracy, clergy, and peasantry run up against a limit of both Christian morality and a practical recognition of the absolute centrality of serf labor in medieval agrarian economies:

To the extent that the peasant was, despite his “fallen” condition or his “lowly” nature, nevertheless partially free and a Christian, he could not simply be dismissed as subhuman, and the question of the purpose of his labor remained complicated by the degree to which it appeared unremunerated. It is this question of recompense that troubled medieval authors to whom, on first glance at least, peasants seemed to be exploited.⁹⁹

The situation is much the same in medieval Iceland, even if we cannot simply transpose these two societies and their worldviews onto each other. But nevertheless, we do find something of this tension in medieval Icelandic representations of slaves. In his work, *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking*, William Miller has cautioned us from seeking a unified slave code in the medieval Icelandic laws,¹⁰⁰ and we might also extend this caveat to literary representations in general. What we find are different images reflecting different mentalities. However, one way of drawing together these heterogenous images is the way in which the body of the slave comes to the foreground in nearly all saga accounts. The slave, as an archetype, is represented as belonging to a lower order of life. Reduced to a mere body, the slave is excluded from spheres of life, such as political action.

⁹⁸ Freedman, *Images of the Medieval Peasant*, 16. This is of course not to conflate the institution of slavery in Medieval Iceland with semi-free serfs on the continent, but there are important similarities in how these are represented and justified.

⁹⁹ Freedman, *Images of the Medieval Peasant*, 16.

¹⁰⁰ Miller, *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking*, 28.

3. The Representation of Agricultural Laborers

At the time of the settlement of Iceland, land was plentiful. Already in 60 years, from between c. 870–930 CE, as we are told in *Íslendingabók*, the best land was taken and new colonists were forced to either buy land from the original settlers, become tenant farmers, or enter the household of a free farmer. From the time of settlement to the *Sturlungaöld*, the social history of Iceland is fundamentally one of the concentration of wealth and power. Agricultural laborers who were neither independent *bændr* nor slaves must surely have composed a significant part of the population by the time of saga production in Iceland. It is perhaps no surprise that we see a general focus on the interests of the *goðar* and *bændr* in medieval Icelandic literature, and, at the other end of the social spectrum, on slaves. Slaves, as we have seen, are a well-established literary trope with a clear character and narrative function. And yet for this large part of the population, the exact legal, social, and economic status of agricultural laborers is often unclear. Here, I consider the narrative role and representations of that class of working men and women from freedmen, itinerant laborers, shepherds and tenant farmers, and consider to what extent their labor is visible in the narrative material.

The Historical Situation

Medieval Norwegian law codes recognized six categories of freemen, each with their own *wergild*: *jarl*, *lenderman*, *hold* (referring to a farmer whose family had owned and worked a farm for four or more generations), *bonde*, *reksthegn* (an agricultural laborer), and *lejsing* (a freedman).¹⁰¹ We see other legal categories in the medieval

¹⁰¹ Sture, “Medieval Agrarian Society in its Prime: Scandinavia,” 652.

sources as well, including *gaardæde* in Denmark in the 14th century. Generally translated as cottagers, this class of peasants received a house from a landowner in exchange for certain obligations.¹⁰² We also see in 14th century Norway a class of *landbo*, or tenant farmers, who were legally equal to landowning peasants, but who were themselves not householders.¹⁰³ Over time, many peasants were forced to sell hereditary land to a tax-free nobility and then farm the land as rent-paying tenants. Strikingly, at the beginning of the 13th century in Denmark, between one half and two-thirds of all land was owned by free farming peasants. By the beginning of the Early Modern period in the 17th century, only some ten percent of Danish land was owned by peasants.¹⁰⁴ Because of this development, the economic and legal divisions between landowning and tenant farmers became less distinct and the individual rights and privileges of these classes can be ambiguous in the sources.¹⁰⁵ This transformation, largely occurring from the beginning of the 12th century to the end of the 13th century from a society of free farmers to rent-paying tenants marks an important shift in the way that wealth was extracted from land. Significantly, leases were also a rather precarious contract, with the *Gulaping* law prescribing tenancies of only one year.¹⁰⁶ Up to the beginning of this period, c. 1050, wealth and power were fundamentally based on control of those who worked the land, and this control took the form of a personal relationship of loyalty, obligation, and tribute.¹⁰⁷ The end of the 11th century saw the rise of princely states in Northern Europe, allied with the church. Along with the

¹⁰² Sture, "Medieval Agrarian Society in its Prime: Scandinavia," 652.

¹⁰³ *ibid*, 655.

¹⁰⁴ *ibid*, 658.

¹⁰⁵ *ibid*, 658.

¹⁰⁶ Iversen and Myking, "Changes in the Nordic Elites' Way of Extracting a Surplus from Landed Resources," 38.

¹⁰⁷ *ibid*, 32.

process of state formation, we also see the shift from a regional class of nobles to a new aristocracy, whose power derived from the sovereign, and whose rule was fundamentally over land, not people.¹⁰⁸ Given these shifting social relations, an important function of the early Norwegian laws was in developing these new concepts of secular authority and possession, especially the concept of landed property.¹⁰⁹ While we cannot simply apply the broader Scandinavian pattern to Iceland (Iceland lacked, for instance, a comparable class of allodial *hold* farmers, as it was of course newly settled land), it serves as a useful point of comparison on which to ground our study of agricultural laborers. Brief as this overview is, I hope that it serves to undermine a certain kind of Icelandic exceptionalism—the idea that the settlement of Iceland was a completely unique political experiment, not subject to the same pressures and processes elsewhere on the continent.

The most fundamental distinction recognized in *Grágás*, the collection of medieval Icelandic law codes in force before the Commonwealth's loss of independence to the Norwegian crown, was between that of the free and unfree.¹¹⁰ Because there were no formal legal distinctions between freemen,¹¹¹ and because Icelandic slavery began to wane already at the beginning of the 11th century,¹¹² this unique feature of Icelandic law has been taken to support the notion of the “free peasant society,” although this view has declined in modern scholarship, especially after the “Anthropological Turn” in saga studies inaugurated by the works of Victor Turner and M.I. Steblin-Kamenskij.

¹⁰⁸ Iversen and Myking, “Changes in the Nordic Elites’ Way of Extracting a Surplus from Landed Resources,” 34.

¹⁰⁹ *ibid.*, 35.

¹¹⁰ Orning, “Class,” 307. In *The Routledge Research Companion to the Medieval Icelandic Sagas*.

¹¹¹ As we shall see, this is not entirely the case.

¹¹² Sørensen, “Saga and Society,” 30.

Nevertheless, Preben Meulgracht Sørensen has spoken of *Grágás* enshrining a “*bóndi* ideology,” in which society is normatively structured around the farmstead, and at its heart, the conjugal pair, or *hjón / hjú*.¹¹³ In broad strokes, this is indeed true. But here, I wish to complicate the image of the *bóndi* society in two ways. At a historical level, we know there must have been many peasants who, though formally equal to the householders, would surely have been socially and economically disadvantaged enough to speak of a forming lower class. Sørensen cites the legal concept of *mannhelgi*, denoting the inviolability of a man’s rights, specifically with regard to equal wergild for freemen, to show that in the Commonwealth, all were theoretically equal before the law, regardless of wealth.¹¹⁴ Of course, even a cursory reading of the sagas will show this to be an ideal not often realized in law cases, with powerful chieftains being able to press their social and economic advantage against their opponents to secure more favorable outcomes. Ross Samson gives the size of an average Icelandic farm at around one or two dozen people, composed variously of kin, workers, freedmen and the like,¹¹⁵ and we see in *Eyrbyggja saga* that Þorsteinn þorskabítr, a well-off chieftain, had some sixty free men in his household.¹¹⁶ Our question here is a simple one: how do we read the medieval Icelandic literature in such a way to gain a better look at these people, who must surely have composed a significant part of the population? We can also call into question the nature of *Grágás*—it may indeed be the case that these law codes were more prescriptive than descriptive in nature. Besides the fundamental free-unfree

¹¹³ Sørensen, *Saga and Society*, 28.

¹¹⁴ Sørensen, “Social Institutions and Belief Systems of Medieval Iceland and Their Relations to Literary Production,” 22. In *Old Icelandic Literature and Society*.

¹¹⁵ Ross Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” 178. In *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*.

¹¹⁶ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*, 18: “Þorsteinn þorskabítr gerðisk inn mesti rausnarmaðr; hann hafði með sér jafnan sex tigu frelsingja.”

distinction, we encounter several terms in *Grágás* that let us view the social class which existed between householders and slaves as something more than an undifferentiated mass. Freedmen, (*leysingi*, *leysingjar*) largely enjoyed the rights of free men, including equal rights in inheritance, betrothal, and personal compensation, with some limitations, including a lesser *wergild* in murder cases.¹¹⁷ The freedman was even allowed a maintenance if necessary, with his freedom-giver being the responsible party: “Sa maðr er frelse gefr manne at hann scal born hans fram föra. iafnt er þat sem vm arf. Þat er vm þræla at sa maðr scal þa fram föra er fe a at þeim.”¹¹⁸ Furthermore, regardless of how well *Grágás* corresponded to contemporary society, we can still ask of it, like Turner and Steblin-Kamenskij, what worldview it puts forward, who it represented, and who is invisible.

Anonymous and Servile: The Trope of the Shepherd

A common, yet under-researched, figure we find in medieval Icelandic literature is that of the shepherd, often *sauðamaðr*, *smalamaðr*, *hirðir*, or *hjarð(ar)sveinn*. The latter two terms generally carry a religious connotation, whereas the former two terms generally occur in a social and economic context. As Richard Cole playfully puts it, these figures resemble the “redshirts” of *Star Trek*: “[t]hey are anonymous, servile, disposable, and normally destined to leave the narrative in a grisly manner not long after they have entered it.”¹¹⁹ Very often, these figures are unindividuated and nameless, simply being killed off by a *draugr* in the larger narrative of a haunting plot. There is an

¹¹⁷ Jón Jóhannesson, *A History of the Old Icelandic Commonwealth*, 344.

¹¹⁸ Vilhjálmur Finsen, ed. *Grágás: Konungsbók*, §112.

¹¹⁹ Cole, “Homotopia, or, Reading Sagas on an Industrial Estate,” 124.

obvious class dynamic at play here, and we may also think of representations of rustics on the Continent as the “small folk,” both in literal physical appearance and in their value. The 14th century French chronicler Froissart, for instance, describes the rustics of his region as “small, dark, and ill-armed,” and many other such examples can be found in the medieval sources.¹²⁰ Shepherds are very often connected to these *draugar* narratives, and William Sayers has interpreted such *draugar* attacks as fundamentally economic in nature, with *draugar* representing the absolute negation of economic productivity: “*Draugr* activity did not cause wealth to circulate in the community, but cut it off at its source.”¹²¹ As we shall see, one of the most commonly destroyed forms of wealth in the saga literature was shepherds. At the bottom rung of the hierarchy, these often-nameless workers are vulnerable and die quickly. And yet, I suggest that we do not merely see a recapitulation of continental caste ideology in the representation of shepherds in medieval Icelandic literature. The position of precarity occupied by these men must surely have been sympathetic to saga audiences, even if they can be said to be reflective of a *goði* or *bóndi* ideology. The shepherd is a figure destined to suffer and die, but also one to be identified with.

The very tight narrative of *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða* revolves around the fallout of the death of such a shepherd. *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða* is a medieval Icelandic saga which most likely dates from the end of the 13th century, though all significant copies of the text only exist in later manuscripts.¹²² Remarkable for its novella-length and focused structure, the saga was of great scholarly interest to the bookprose theorists of the

¹²⁰ Freedman, *Images of the Medieval Peasant*, 139. For an example of such physical embodiments of caste ideology in a Norse context, see the useful discussion of *Rígsþula* in: Karras, *Slavery and Society in Medieval Scandinavia*. 61-2.

¹²¹ Sayers, “The Alien and Alienated as Unquiet Undead,” 259. In *Monster Theory*.

¹²² Kratz, “Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða,” 301. In *Medieval Scandinavia: An Encyclopedia*.

Icelandic school, as they interpreted it to be an exemplar of Icelandic literary innovation, prefiguring the modern novel and novella forms.¹²³ The saga revolves around the eponymous Hrafnkell, a local chieftain said to be in the favor of the god Freyr. A shepherd boy comes to work on his farmstead, and after being warned to not ride a sacred horse which has been dedicated to the patron god, he rides it and is executed, albeit grudgingly. Hrafnkell offers generously to support Einarr, the boy's father, and to help him with his remaining children, but significantly, not as legal compensation, but more formally as a kind of charity or patronage. Intent on justice, the economically and socially inferior family of the slain shepherd insist on pressing a court case as free and equal farmers. Through much conflict and legal wrangling, Hrafnkell temporarily loses, then regains his social and economic capital. As such, the saga has been variously interpreted as a meditation on fate, a reactionary morality play, as a source on pre-Christian religious rites, and as a Christian fantasy of the pagan world.¹²⁴

As the tragedy begins, we find perhaps one of the more moving scenes in the saga literature. The father, Þorbjörn, all too aware of the mouths to feed at home, tells his son Einarr, that he must find work:

Þorbjörn átti fé lítit, en ómegð mikla. Sonr hans hét Einarr, inn elzti. Hann var mikill ok vel mannaðr. Þat var á einu vári, at Þorbjörn mælti til Einars, at hann mundi leita sér vistar nokkurar, – því at ek þarf eigi meira forvirki en þetta lið orkar, er hér er, en þér mun verða gott til vista, því at þú ert mannaðr vel. Eigi veldr ástleysi þessari brottkvaðning við þik, því at þú ert mér þarfastr barna minna. Meira veldr því efnaleysi mitt ok fátækð. En önnur börn mín gerask verkmenn. Mun þér þó verða betra til vista en þeim.¹²⁵

¹²³ Kratz, "Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða," 301. In *Medieval Scandinavia: An Encyclopedia*.

¹²⁴ See: Fulk, "The Moral System of Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða" for a useful overview of the scholarship on the saga.

¹²⁵ Jón Jóhannesson, ed. *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða*, 101. In *Austfirðinga sǫgur*.

We do not often catch glimpses of the love between parent and child in medieval Icelandic literature, and this scene is highly emotionally charged when compared to other sagas. Þorbjörn, for instance, ensures his son that it is not for a lack of love that he must go out and find work, but necessity. He also notes with resignation that his other children must become workmen, but that he hopes it fares better for Einarr, his eldest. We may also note here that, far from being “small, dark, and ill-armed,” as the under-class is described in *Rígsþula*, that Einarr is “mikill ok vel mannaðr.” In addition to his physical strength, we might also assume that Einarr is virtuous and deserving of a better fate than awaits him. However, it is late in the season, close to the moving-days when one was legally obligated to register at a farmstead, and there is no time to find good work. Einarr laments: “Of síð hefir þú sagt mér til þessa, því at nú hafa allir ráðit sér vistir, þær er beztar eru, en mér þykkir þó illt at hafa órval af.”¹²⁶ Einarr knows he will only get the worst of labor, and as the narrative develops, he is vindicated: to become a shepherd is a death sentence.

The ethical “ambiguities” of *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða* may make for murkier interpretation of the shepherd figure than in other narratives. We may ask whether Hrafnkell is justified in his slaying of Einarr, as a neutral arbiter or divine justice, or if Hrafnkell’s eventual triumph can be seen as a rejection of the more rustic sympathies we see elsewhere in the text. A narrative that I hold to be more typical of the shepherd trope is found in *Grettis saga Ásmundarsonar*. *Grettis saga* is an Icelandic saga which narrates the life of Grettir, a famously strong figure renowned as the longest-outlawed figure in saga literature. *Grettis saga* stands out in several ways from other members of

¹²⁶ Jón Jóhannesson, ed. *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða*, 101. In *Austfirðinga sögur*.

the saga corpus. It is dated later than many other *Íslendingasögur*, generally placed in the beginning of the 14th century, and perhaps even in the beginning of the 15th. The earliest manuscript evidence we have dates from c. 1500.¹²⁷ It is also noteworthy for its setting, taking place entirely after Icelandic conversion, and for the preponderance of supernatural elements in the narrative. The supernatural elements are of interest here. Grettir, later outlawed, lives on the edges of the settled world, fighting monsters and beasts. As such, we can read *Grettis saga* as fundamentally a story about inclusion and exclusion from the life of the *bær*.¹²⁸

The turning point of the saga occurs with Grettir's encounter with the *draugr* Glámr. Þórhallr, a wealthy farmer, has difficulty finding workers because of a haunting on his farmstead: "Þat er svá háttat, at mér helzk lítt á sauðamönnum; verðr þeim heldr klaksárt, en sumir gera engar lykðir á; vill nú engi til taka sá, er kunnigt er til, hvat fyrir býr."¹²⁹ Notably, the farmer is intent on hiring help, knowing full well what may come—one thinks, perhaps, of the manager of a modern workplace, ready to write off a *draugr* as a workplace hazard, to be sure, but nothing to be concerned about. Þórhallr is recommended Glámr, who comes to work at his farmstead. Glámr is described as being not given to worship and having no faith: "Kirkja var á Þórhallsstöðum; ekki vildi Glámr til hennar koma; hann var ósöngvinn ok trúlauss, stirfinn ok viðskotailr; qllum var hann hvimleiðr."¹³⁰ Later, on Christmas Eve, Glámr requests his food as usual but is informed by the farmer's wife that it is not tradition to eat on Christmas. To this Glámr responds: "Marga hindrvitni hafi þér, þá er ek sé til einskis koma; veit ek eigi, at

¹²⁷ Vésteinn Ólasson, "Family Sagas," 115.

¹²⁸ On the role of Nature and Culture as it relates to the status of outlawry, see: Barraclough, "Inside Outlawry in *Grettis saga Ásmundarsonar* and *Gísla saga Súrssonar*."

¹²⁹ Guðni Jónsson, ed. *Grettis saga*, §32.

¹³⁰ *ibid.*

monnum fari nú betr at heldr en þá, er menn váru heiðnir kallaðir, ok vil ek hafa mat minn, en engar refjur.”¹³¹ We see here how Glámr places himself outside of all human community by rejecting the Christian faith. It is even further implied by his regard of all belief as superstition that he may not have been heathen either, despite his preference for these times. Glámr is clearly represented as a totally alien presence on the farmstead, not belonging entirely to the world of the *bær*.

As the narrative advances, Glámr is killed in a haunting and Grettir, upon visiting the farmstead, is called upon to end Glámr, who has now turned into a revenant, or *draugr*. *Draugar* are common figures in the medieval Icelandic sagas and are rather notable in the otherwise realistic narratives. Simek distinguishes *draugar* from other known revenant figures, such as the *Nachzehrer*, and states that the decisive difference between the types is that the *draugr* physically leaves its grave and causes material damage.¹³² Glámr is a figure who straddles boundaries, rather literally. Supernatural beings, in the medieval North and elsewhere, are often associated with boundary crossing, often in very everyday contexts concerning doors and roofs. We see a very clear reference to this trope in the narrative: “Því næst tók Glámr at ríða húsum á nætr, svá at lá við brotum; gekk hann þá nálíga nætr ok daga.”¹³³ This is a potential reference to the notion of “roof riding,” in which supernatural beings, such as witches, trolls, and revenants would straddle the roofbeam of a farmstead. This trope need not refer specifically to a roof, but many thresholds of the farmstead that formed symbolic boundaries are included as well. Mitchell, in his *Witchcraft and Magic in the Nordic*

¹³¹ Guðni Jónsson, ed. *Grettis saga*, §32.

¹³² Simek, *Religion und Mythologie der Germanen*, 265.

¹³³ Guðni Jónsson, ed. *Grettis saga*, §32.

Middle Ages discusses this trope as it relates to gender and witches. It was a form of slander to accuse a woman of such action, as such boundary-straddling was often associated with the demonic in the Christian Middle Ages:

[T]he woman's appearance and behavior are marked in the extreme: she is seen riding [...] a gate in the form of a "troll." [...] Both the time and place of her conduct are carefully specified, and both have important cultural connections: she is said to have ridden the gate at a liminal point in time, "when all was even between night and day," [...] either at the equinox or at twilight or at some combination of the two times. Liminality is also the hallmark of the location where she engaged in this apparently odious behavior: by its very nature and purpose, a gate represents a boundary between areas and therefore also a threshold from one domain into the other. Gates and pen fences underscore the fact that the act has taken place in the shadowlands between the two areas.¹³⁴

I read Glámr's roof riding as a part of this topos, underscoring his belonging in neither the natural world, nor the ordered community of the farmstead. Grettir is also very conscious of these dynamics. As they fight, Glámr tries to escape out the door of the farmstead: "Vildi Glámr leita út, en Grettir færði við fœtr, hvar sem hann mátti, en þó gat Glámr dregit hann fram ór skálanum. Áttu þeir þá allharða sókn, því at þrællinn ætlaði at koma honum út ór bönum; en svá illt, sem at eiga var við Glám inni, þá sá Grettir, at þó var verra at fásk við hann úti."¹³⁵ There is a sense in which Glámr's power is connected to the landscape itself, and that being out-of-doors will make him more powerful. Finally, Grettir defeats the revenant and ritually dishonors his body. Before his second and final death, Glámr puts the curse on Grettir which will determine the rest of the narrative: he will never grow stronger than he is that day, and we will always fear the dark, never being able to be alone. The case of Glámr is perhaps a special one with regard to the shepherd trope. He is certainly less servile and anonymous than other

¹³⁴ Mitchell, *Witchcraft and Magic in the Nordic Middle Ages*, 151.

¹³⁵ Guðni Jónsson, ed. *Grettis saga*, §35.

examples we might discuss. What interests us, however, is importance of symbolic boundaries in the Glámr narrative, and how this shepherd-worker is represented as not belonging to the same domestic sphere as the others on the farmstead. Indeed, his supernatural status as a *draugr* identifies him with all manner of dangerous boundary-crossers. In Glámr's case, being a shepherd is not just a death sentence, it is also a direct threat to the ordered life of the farmstead community.

Vagrants and Itinerant Workers

As Sørensen states, medieval Icelandic society was normatively structured around the farmstead as both the social and economic center of life. As such, the *Grágás* legal codes put great emphasis on the need for all souls to be registered at the farm of a *bóndi*. Notably, we do see an explicit exception for skilled laborers. Section 78, “vm heimilis föng,” of the *Konungsbók* manuscript of *Grágás* reads as follows: “Smiðar þeir er hus gera or avstrønom viðe eða bruar vm ar þær eða votn er net næmir físcar ganga í. eða gera buðir a alþingi. þeir eigo cost at taca daga cavp vm engi verk. þeir scolo tekit hafa þo ser log grið afar dögom. þott þeir hirði eigi þat.”¹³⁶ This exception seems to be made for these individuals, as they possessed highly in-demand skills which necessarily required travel “on the job,” as it were. The structures mentioned are also of interest. Norwegian wood, a highly sought-after commodity, must not have been a building material trusted to any common farmhand. The scarce resource situation in Iceland already during the time of *Grágás* must have allowed for some

¹³⁶ Vilhjálmur Finsen, ed. *Grágás: Konungsbók*, §78. “Smiths who make houses of Eastern (Norwegian) wood or bridges over rivers or lakes where fish run that can be netted or who build booths at the Althing may choose to take day wages for outfield haymaking. They must, however, have found themselves legal domicile in the moving days, even if they disregard it.” translation from Dennis et al, with my own modifications.

leniency in the otherwise strict residence rules in order to make the most of this precious resource. Bridges and booths as well must have been highly important, as some of the first proto-public infrastructure in the commonwealth, with bridges helping to improve trade and communications among the quarters, and booths, although privately owned, as the prerequisite for the legal assemblies.¹³⁷ What interests us, however, is while vagrancy hovered over society as a constant threat, economically productive individuals were trusted with itineracy. I interpret the object of *Grágás*' concerns not to be mainly a kind of proto-bureaucratic drive towards registration, but instead the fear of unproductive mouths and bodies threatening community cohesion.¹³⁸ With this historical perspective, we see that vagrants in the saga literature are often portrayed as antisocial, unproductive, and expendable. Like many of the social groups under consideration here, we see a wide range of terminology applied to vagrants, from *göngumenn*, *einhleypingar* and *staðkarlar*. Our goal, however, is not to get at a historical reality. Vagrants, an umbrella term we shall use for freemen and women not firmly integrated into a farmstead-centered kinship unit, are necessarily a hard group to track, likely leaving no mark on their community. As both a legal category and literary trope, however, we gain insight into the normative assumptions of medieval Iceland, and how it expected individuals to become integrated into economically productive structures.

¹³⁷ On the role of such early public infrastructure on the consolidation of *goði* power, see: Jón Jóhannesson, *A History of the Old Icelandic Commonwealth*, 236.

¹³⁸ See also the Commonwealth institution of the *hreppr*, *hreppar*. Possibly predating Christian conversion and consisting of some ~20 attendance-due paying farmsteads, the exact structure and function of these communes is unclear, but it seems they provided some basic welfare and insurance against fire, crop failure, and poverty. There may have been a sense of Christian goodwill and altruism, but the immediate, pragmatic purpose seems to be stopping failed farmsteads and problematic individuals from becoming a communal problem. Vilhjálmur Finsen, ed. *Grágás: Konungsbók*, §234, “vm hreppa scil.”

Section 254 of the *Konungsbók* manuscript of *Grágás* flies in the face of more romantic interpretations of medieval Iceandic law and its category of *mannhelgi*—the inviolable legal rights and dignity of a free man. The section reads as follows: “Rett er at gellda gongo men oc varðar eigi við lög þoat þeir fae örkumbl af eða bana.”¹³⁹ While there must certainly have been cases of runaway slaves, this passage does not refer to them; it concerns free men, legally but not socially or economically equal to *bændr*. We have seen the tragic consequences of poverty in *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoði*, in which the impoverished Þorbjörn must send his son away to work at an inopportune time, for want of food for the mouths at home. Clearly, on one level, this law acts as an early attempt at social planning, presumably to limit the number of unproductive mouths and bodies in the future. And for economically unproductive, yet nevertheless free, men to lose their most fundamental expression of bodily autonomy—the ability to reproduce—is rather disturbing to modern sensibilities. Although not a slave, the figure of the vagrant was a dangerous one which stood in opposition to the integrated order of the Icelandic farmstead. In his ecocritical reading of *Eyrbyggja saga*, Carl Phelpstead suggests that the most fundamental ecological distinction to the medieval Icelandic mind was not that between Culture and Nature, but that between humans and domesticated animals on the one hand, and wild animals on the other.¹⁴⁰ This view has much to recommend it, and we see in both the sagas and the archaeological record how the closely humans and animals must have lived together on the Icelandic farmstead, forming a “humananimal community,” in Phelpstead’s terminology.¹⁴¹ And yet the above section in *Grágás*

¹³⁹ Vilhjálmur Finsen, ed. *Grágás: Konungsbók*, §254. “It is lawful to castrate vagrants and there is no legal penalty even if they get lasting injury or death from it.” Translation from Dennis et al.

¹⁴⁰ Phelpstead, *Ecocriticism and Eyrbyggja saga*, 14.

¹⁴¹ *ibid.*

suggests that all humans were not fully considered such. The salient distinction might be rather that between the domesticated economic order of the *bær*, inclusive of both humans and animals working together in their pursuit of net-positive caloric production, and wild animals and vagrants, who at best represent economically unproductive bodies to maintain, and at worst, direct threats to the functioning order of the *bær*.

In their article, “Gossips, Beggars, Assassins, Tramps: Vagrants and Other Itinerants in the Sagas of Icelanders,” Cochrane suggests a symbolic connection between the vagrant and other legal and supernatural figures coded as other, from outlaws to trolls: “Farmers who had fallen into misfortune were to be protected by society, as they were still very much part of that society. But vagrants of the other sort had chosen their own lifestyle and had more in common with the trolls and creatures roaming the landscape with humans.”¹⁴² Cochrane connects this sense of alterity with the term *ómennska*, which we find in *Grágás*’ description of the vagrant, in which illegal vagrants are defined as travelling under *ómennska*. Vagrants in such conditions did not have the same property rights as other free men, and could neither inherit property, nor claim personal damages.¹⁴³ Connected to *maðr*, *mennska*, could refer either to a kind of human nature or humanity as a noun. As an adjective, *mennskr*, referred quite simply to a man as opposed to giants, trolls, or other supernatural beings. *Ómennska*, translated in Dennis et al. as “perversity,” is clearly the opposite to these

¹⁴² Cochrane, “Gossips, Beggars, Assassins, Tramps: Vagrants and Other Itinerants in the Sagas of Icelanders,” 46.

¹⁴³ “Þar at eins er sa maðr arf gengr er averðgangi er alin oc á at taca erfþir oc þau gøðe er því eigo at fylgia ef faþir hans moðir gengo eigi fyrir omenzco sacir oc þo eigi fyr enn hann hefir haft vist vi. misseri.” Vilhjálmur Finsen, ed. *Grágás: Konungsbók*, §118. “A man born of parents who go begging for food is a lawful heir with the right to take inheritances and the benefits that go with them only if his father and mother are not vagrant because of perversity, and even then not before he has settled lodging for six seasons.” Translation from Dennis et al.

terms, both in an ethical sense of lacking virtue, i.e., unmanly, and perhaps in a more cosmological sense of not belonging to the *bær*-as-world. Here I wish to distinguish between two kinds of non-belonging to the community. Outlawry has long been interpreted as a kind of social death, the outlawed individual stripped of all connection to the legal community and placed completely outside it.¹⁴⁴ Related to this social death are the various terms and images which align the outlaw, as both a historical legal category and literary-mythical trope, with nature, the radical other of culture: *vargr* and *skóggangr* being some of the most common.¹⁴⁵ The outlaw, we can say, is radically excluded from the *bær*. It would be easy to draw parallels here to the figure of the vagrant, but these two types are meaningfully distinct, both legally and symbolically. Whereas the life of the outlaw is forfeit, the vagabond nevertheless stands in an uneasy relationship with their community, neither totally part nor totally exterior to it. The vagabond is often figured as begging for food and vagrants are often employed as seasonal agricultural laborers. Despite their exclusion from many of the basic rights enjoyed by Icelandic freemen, the vagabond nevertheless stands in a relationship to the *bær* that the outlaw cannot.

Section Conclusion

The agricultural laborer is a difficult figure to get a direct look at in the saga literature. The Icelandic farmstead was very much the center of medieval Icelandic society, and we see a strict symbolic regulation of who belongs to this economic community, and who doesn't. Shepherds have proven to be an interesting literary trope,

¹⁴⁴ Brink, "Slavery in the Viking Age," 50. In *The Viking World*.

¹⁴⁵ Byock, "Outlawry," 460. In *Medieval Scandinavia: An Encyclopedia*.

as they stand in a relationship to the farm, but nevertheless are excluded from total integration. This not-quite-belonging reflects a general fear of itineracy in medieval Icelandic society, which required workers to be registered at a farmstead. Nevertheless, the narrative sources do not only detail the ways in which individuals were excluded from integration into the farmstead. There are moments of sympathy and identity with the agricultural laborer as well, as we have seen in the case of Einarr in *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða*. This saga, whatever its “ambiguities” and overall moral system, seems to show an irreducible class conflict between the chieftain and laborer class. While the narrative core of this saga may betray something fundamentally reactionary, I nevertheless read in the scene between Einarr and his father a moment of peasant sympathy, undermining any simple notion of a one-sided class interest. We have also seen the way in which agricultural laborers were required to belong to a farmstead, and the fear of vagrancy this may reflect. Skilled and productive carpenters were allowed greater freedom of movement, but the diverse group of *göngumenn* and *einhleypingar* faced both symbolic exclusion and even castration, despite their formal equality under the law. These figures are also often associated with supernatural beings as “other” to the ordered life of the farmstead, and to understand this symbolic alignment, we have drawn on ecocritical categories which draw a distinction not just between humans and animals, but perhaps more fundamentally between domestic and wild men and animals. As always, our images of agricultural laborers in medieval Iceland are complex, representing as many classes and interests as lived in medieval Iceland.

4. The Representation of Chieftain Labor

During the time of the Icelandic Commonwealth, a *goði* (pl. *goðar*) was the holder of a *goðorð* (chieftaincy). This chieftaincy was considered to be a kind of property, and as such, it could be sold, inherited, and also shared.¹⁴⁶ The office seems to have originated within a sacral context, likely a priest responsible for maintenance of a temple, and while we do have saga attestations of this function of the *goði*, such as in *Eyrbyggja saga*, the primary role of *goðar* during the Commonwealth period was fundamentally legal and political in nature. The medieval *Grágás* law codes prescribe an original number of 36, later enlarged to 48, for the *goðar*,¹⁴⁷ and although Commonwealth Iceland lacked anything like an executive branch, they fulfilled some rudimentary public roles, such as presiding over confiscation courts. One of the main functions fulfilled by *goðar* was that of a legal mediator and patron. The clients, or *þingmenn*, of a *goði* would often come to have a legal case pressed on their behalf, the social power of the *goði* more likely to bring about a favorable ruling than if pressed by the farmer alone. In this way, the chieftain-client relationship could be said to be reciprocal, with *þingmenn* offered the protection of a *goði*, who could in turn call on his *þingmenn* for support. Significantly, it was the legal right of all *þingmenn* to choose their *goði*, and as the power of a *goði* derived not from control over territory, but from kinship and client networks, there was freedom among farmers to give and withhold their allegiance freely.¹⁴⁸ Of course, we might imagine many scenarios in which a farmer with very little social capital is dominated by a neighboring *goði*, and numerous

¹⁴⁶ Byock, "Goði," 230. In *Routledge Encyclopedia of Medieval Scandinavia*.

¹⁴⁷ Some doubt has been cast on these traditional numbers, perhaps as post-hoc fabrications. cf. Jón Viðar Sigurðsson, *Chieftains and Power in the Icelandic Commonwealth*, 40-1.

¹⁴⁸ Gunnar Karlsson, "Goðar and Höfðingjar in Medieval Iceland," 359.

episodes from the sagas bear this out. Over time, *goði*-power became more and more concentrated, with approximately 26 families with political influence around the beginning of the 12th century, and only some 7 at the end of the 13th century on the eve of the *Sturlungaöld*.¹⁴⁹ This concentration of power also saw a fundamental shift in the nature of chieftainship, and where traditional *goðar* could be said to “rule” over a network of clients and kin, the new model was increasingly territorial. Accelerating this trend towards centralization was also the peculiar relationship between the church and the chieftain class in Iceland; by the 13th century, farmsteads with churches, or *staðir*, became the most important financial property for chieftains, with approximately half of all householders paying their tithe to a *goði*-controlled church.¹⁵⁰ While the goal here is not to merely apply continental patterns onto Iceland, we can say that whereas the traditional office of *goði* did perform some function in a community, the later model of *goði* power was increasingly exploitative in a way that conforms, in broad strokes, to models of feudal landowning on the Continent.

Though the sagas were doubtlessly read aloud on farmsteads to a broad audience and written down by amanuenses, we can nevertheless say that the *goðar* were both largely the producers and intended audience of the sagas. As such, when we consider this shift in the nature of *goði* power, it seems likely that there is a corresponding change in *goði* self-consciousness, and how the class represents itself. Torfi Tulinius, for instance, has argued in his work, *The Matter of the North*, that saga production was in large part the response of an emerging *goði* class to construct an identity, while

¹⁴⁹ Jón Viðar Sigurðsson. “The Icelandic Chieftains and their Economic Foundation c. 1050 – 1250.” In *Nordic Elites in Transformation, c. 1050 – 1250*. 281.

¹⁵⁰ *ibid.*

simulateously distinguishing itself from the emerging peasant class: “In all of these texts there can be found reflections, more or less distinct, of a society undergoing profound change: change in the internal organization of the ruling classes and in their self-image, if not in the fundamental structure of society itself.”¹⁵¹ Given the intimate relationship between *goði* power and literary production, these changes in models of rulership and political organization are of particular interest to us. But accompanying these real social changes were also new ideologies of rulership imported from the courtly literature of the Continent: “The aristocratic model that had spread across Europe in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries is an important factor in the changes going on in Iceland at this time, though Icelanders did not slavishly imitate that model. Though this model brought with it profound upheavals and political changes, its impact was mainly on the level of ideology. And literature is a privileged form in which ideology expresses itself.”¹⁵² There is little doubt that the medieval Icelandic sagas can be interpreted to some degree as the expression of a class interest, and to the degree that the power of *goðar* was instrumental in medieval Icelandic literary production, the question of *goði* self-image might simply be said to be co-extensive with saga scholarship itself. In the following section, we shall inquire into the representation of *goði* labor and how it might have changed during this period, but because of the inherently social nature of their labors, that is, increasingly exploitative landholders, we must also consider the chieftain class in its relationship to Icelandic society more broadly. Although we certainly see an emerging class-consciousness among the chieftains, it nevertheless seems that the chieftains still fundamentally viewed

¹⁵¹ Torfi Tulinius, *The Matter of the North*, 290 – 1.

¹⁵² *ibid*, 291.

themselves as farmers, and as such, images of chieftain labor are given precedent in the narrative sources.

Historical Awareness and Changing Norms

Historical consciousness has long been considered one of the defining features of the Icelandic sagas.¹⁵³ The sagas are, of course, semi-historical narratives, but what is of interest to us is the way in which saga authors are aware of themselves as constructing a narrative, and how a historical “then” is contrasted to the “now” of composition. This genre feature surfaces in many ways, but one of the more common forms of this trope regards customs which differed from the saga-age and their time of writing. One example of this is to be found in the hauntings of the *Fróðá* episode in *Eyrbyggja saga*: “Eptir andlát Þóris tók sótt húskarl Þórodds ok lá þrjár nætr, áðr hann andaðisk; síðan dó hverr at qðrum, þar til er sex váru látnir; var þá komit at jólaföstu, en þó var þann tíma eigi fastat á Íslandi.”¹⁵⁴ *Eyrbyggja saga* is an excellent object to study with regard to such historical consciousness in the face of social transformation, as it has been especially highlighted as focusing on the role of the *goði* in Icelandic society, precisely at the time in which this office was being threatened and transformed by both royal and ecclesiastical power.¹⁵⁵ In the scholarship, this historical consciousness is generally discussed with regard to the loss of independence to Norway and the attempts

¹⁵³ The nature of the saga’s historicity has of course been a topic of long debate, but it suffices to note here that, “the form of the narratives is influenced by the society and its ideology—not necessarily as it actually was in reality, but as it is portrayed in the text. Consequently, it is not possible to say that the world presented in the sagas is identical with the world in which the events related took place, or with the world at the time that they were written.” Vésteinn Ólasson, “Family Sagas,” 103. In *A Companion to Old Norse-Icelandic Literature and Culture*.

¹⁵⁴ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Eyrbyggja saga*. §53.

¹⁵⁵ Torfi Tulinius, “Dating *Eyrbyggja saga*,” 129.

of the Icelandic Commonwealth to construct an identity just as that identity was coming under threat, and also with regard to the changing customs and laws after the Christian conversion.¹⁵⁶ Here, however, I would like to briefly consider some ways in which the saga literature was conscious not just of political and religious transformation, but of fundamentally economic changes as well.

Two minor passages from the sagas give us some insight into the changing social relations of the time. The first, from *Vatnsdæla saga*, emphasizes how it was common for the sons of wealthy men, “in that time,” to have some occupation: “Þess er getit, at veiðr mikil var í Vatnsdalsá, bæði laxa ok annarra fiska; þeir skiptu með sér verkum bræðr, synir Ingimundar, því at þat var siðr ríkra manna sona í þann tíma, at hafa nokkura iðn fyrir hendi.”¹⁵⁷ A similar sense is echoed in *Sqrla þáttr*, a fragmented later addition to *Ljósvetninga saga*,¹⁵⁸ a family saga which centers around the chieftain Guðmundr inn ríki:

Þat er sagt, at Guðmundr inn ríki var mjök fyrir öðrum mǫnnum um rausn sína. Hann hafði hundrað hjóna ok hundrað kúa. Þat var ok siðr hans at láta lǫngum vera með sér gǫfugra manna sonu, ok setti þá svá ágætliga, at þeir skyldi engan hlut eiga at iðja annan en vera ávallt í samsæti með honum. En þat var þó sá siðr þeira, er þeir vǫru heima, at þeir unnu, þó at þeir væri af gǫfgum ættum.¹⁵⁹

Notably, it is emphasized here that the sons work *despite* coming from a wealthy family. Both of these passages construct a clear “then,” in which it was supposedly common for sons of wealthy chieftains to work, and a “now” in which it is presumably no longer the case. It does seem likely that this minor saga trope does correspond to the

¹⁵⁶ Whaley, “A Useful Past: Historical Writing in Medieval Iceland,” 182-4.

¹⁵⁷ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Vatnsdæla saga*, §22.

¹⁵⁸ Magerøy, “Ljósvetninga saga,” 394. In *Medieval Scandinavia: An Encyclopedia*.

¹⁵⁹ Björn Sigfússon, ed. *Sqrla þáttr*, §1. In *Ljósvetninga saga með þáttum*.

historical situation, as we have traced the ways in which *goði* power became more concentrated over time. Christopher Wickham has described this accumulation of power as a byproduct of the shift away from peasant production, characterized by the centrality of the individual household and impermanent hierarchies, to the feudal mode of production, which as in Iceland and on the continent, was characterized by economic control by a hereditary landowning elite.¹⁶⁰ Wickham also discusses the several scenes in the sagas where *goðar* are depicted as tending to their own farms as a genuine expression of this peasant mode of production.¹⁶¹ Arnkell, once again in *Eyrbyggja saga*, is for instance depicted repairing the door of his farmstead when Þorleifr makes an attempt on his life.¹⁶² Wickham contends that these depictions of *goðar*, who were still involved in the day-to-day running of their farms reflects more broadly a society in which wealth was accumulated not as much through exploitation, as through their ability to manage relations with their neighbors and pursue their interests at court. When we consider scenes such as the episode with Arnkell, or the industrious chieftains' sons, it becomes clear during the time of saga writing, this is no longer the case.

One of the best images we have of *goði*-labor is from *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða*, which we have also discussed above with regard to the role of shepherds and class dynamics. After his setback at the hands of Sámr and his allies, Hrafnkell must work again for a living. Significantly, he is not restarting from “ground zero,” however, and the narrative gives us a rare insight into the interplay between social,

¹⁶⁰ Wickham, “Passages to Feudalism,” 144.

¹⁶¹ *ibid.*, 147.

¹⁶² Einar Sveinsson, ed. “Arnkell stóð upp snimma um morguninn ok negldi saman útihurð sína; en er Þorleifr reis upp, gekk hann til Arnkels ok beiddi hann viðrtöku.” *Eyrbyggja saga*, §35.

cultural, and economic capital in medieval Iceland. Specifically, Hrafnkell is able to raise credit to buy a farm: “Hrafnkell færði nú bú sitt austr yfir Fljótsdalsheiði ok um þveran Fljótsdal fyrir austan Lagarfljót. Við vatnsbotninn stóð einn lítill bær, sem hét at Lokhillu. Þetta land keypti Hrafnkell í skuld, því at eigi var kostrinn meiri en þurfti til búshluta hafa.”¹⁶³ While he has lost some of his standing, he nevertheless retains enough social capital to leverage it into the economic capital needed to restart his life, and we might assume that this option would not be available for lesser farmers. Nevertheless, despite this clear advantage, the resurgence of Hrafnkell is portrayed as coming from his industriousness, thrift, and clever investing: “Þetta var skógland mikit ok mikit merkjum, vánt at húsum, ok fyrir þat efni keypti hann landit litlu verði. En Hrafnkell sá ekki mjök í kostnað ok felldi mörkina, því at hon var stór, ok reisti þar reisiligan bæ, þann er síðan hét á Hrafnkelsstöðum. Hefir þat síðan verit kallaðr jafnan góðr bær.”¹⁶⁴ He is able to not think much of the cost because of his already-established social standing, but the narrative clearly frames this miraculous recovery as being linked to his own industriousness: “Hrafnkell gekk mjök at verknaði, meðan bær var í smíði.”¹⁶⁵ Of course, Hrafnkell is also said to be favored by his patron god, and so his recovery may also be thanks to more supernatural means. We may see a hint at this in the suggestion that his farm was so prosperous, it was almost as if his beasts had two heads each: “Mátti svá at kveða, at nálíga væri tvau höfuð á hverju kvikindi.”¹⁶⁶ Is this an early expression of what Max Weber identified as the “Protestant work ethic?” Is Hrafnkell so successful because he is already favored by his god, and his outward

¹⁶³ Jón Jóhannesson, ed. *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða*, 121-2. In *Austfirðinga sǫgur*.

¹⁶⁴ *ibid.*, 122.

¹⁶⁵ *ibid.*

¹⁶⁶ *ibid.*

wealth is just a sign of his elect status? Perhaps, and perhaps not. What seems to be of great importance, however, is that Hrafnkell is represented as not just an exploitative overlord. His natural position is at the top of the hierarchy, we are led to believe, because of his intelligence and work ethic. Indeed, even when he has lost this position, he naturally “floats” back to the top. Clearly, it is important for *goðar* to consider themselves not just as landlords, but as the most effective laborers as well.

Sources of *Goði* Wealth and Rent Collection

A central question for scholars of medieval Iceland has centered around the sources of *goði* wealth. Jón Jóhannesson has influentially claimed that the office of *goði* was not lucrative at all, arguing that the majority of the fees levied on clients by *goðar* were largely to recuperate expenses, and that the office of *goði* was fundamentally not an exploitative one.¹⁶⁷ Jesse Byock has expressed a similar sentiment: “The income a chieftain received from performing legally designated governmental duties was too little and too irregular to explain how successful chieftains amassed the wealth necessary to purchase support, pay compensation awards, exchange gifts, make loans, and provide feasts and hospitality.”¹⁶⁸ We have situated both Jón Jóhannesson and Byock within the broadly liberal historiographic tradition outlined in the introduction, and while this may have been true at early stages in the Commonwealth, the power and influence of a *goði* cannot be so neatly isolated into formal legal rights and other economic interests, especially later in the Commonwealth period when the transition to territorial lordship was underway. It is, however, an orthodox view in the scholarship that thing- and

¹⁶⁷ Jón Jóhannesson, *History of the Old Icelandic Commonwealth*, 62.

¹⁶⁸ Byock, *Medieval Iceland: Society, Sagas, and Power*. 77.

temple-taxes never represented a significant amount of income for *goðar*.¹⁶⁹ Jón Viðar Sigurðsson contends that one of the most important ways for *goðar* to acquire wealth consisted not in vertical exploitation, but instead, horizontal maneuvering including marriage, inheritance, *heimildir* (warranty, proof of authority) or *handsal* (formal handshake agreement), both of these terms referring to formal agreements to control farmsteads.¹⁷⁰ Notably, inheritance practice, *heimildir*, and *handsal* all form a central concern in *Sturlunga saga*, reflecting both the importance of inheritance as a source of wealth, and also the centralizing tendency of power during the *Sturlungaöld*.¹⁷¹

Perhaps one of the best examples of this is Snorri Sturluson's acquisition of Reykholt as detailed in *Sturlunga saga*. Reykholt was then one of the wealthiest farms in Iceland, in addition to being a *staðr*, or church property, with all the associated tithing rights—an increasingly important source of income for the *goðar*. Magnus, the owner of Reykholt, was old and unable to manage the farm himself. Using his social capital, Snorri is able to leverage warranties from those with rights to the land, and they agree that Snorri will take over Magnus' chieftaincy while looking after the old man and his family. This is seen as a turning point in the narrative: “Snorri Sturluson fór búi sínu í Reykjaholt eptir samning þeira Magnúss prests. Gerðist hann þá höfðingi mikill, því at eigi skorti fé.”¹⁷² It is apparently only now in the narrative that Snorri is to be regarded as a great chieftain, and we are left in no doubt as to why—“for he was not

¹⁶⁹ Ross Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” in *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*. 169.

¹⁷⁰ Jón Viðar Sigurðsson. “The Icelandic Chieftains and their Economic Foundation c. 1050–1250.” In *Nordic Elites in Transformation, c. 1050–1250*. 279.

¹⁷¹ Vogt, “Inheritance and Transfer of Landed Property: The Material Fundament of the Elites.” in *Nordic Elites in Transformation, c. 1050–1250*. 108.

¹⁷² Guðrún Ása Grímsdóttir, ed. *Sturlunga saga*, §153.

short of money.” Snorri’s transformation is also preceded by the oneiric appearance of his ancestor, Egill Skalla-Grímsson, to one of his household men, Egill Halldórsson. The scene is rather difficult to interpret, as we might expect an ancestral blessing upon Snorri’s ascendance and triumph, but Egill (Skalla-Grímsson) is described as “frowning” (*ófrýnligr*) and warns Snorri from moving away from Borg. The key to this scene may lie in the verses which the ancestral skald recites: “Seggr sparir sverði at höggva, / snjóhvítt er blóð líta, / skæruöld getum skýra, / skarpr brandr fekk mér landa, / skarpr brandr fekk mér landa.”¹⁷³ The last lines seem especially important and are highlighted by repetition. Is this a lament of “the old ways,” when wealth was taken openly through violence, not negotiated for and won through legal wrangling? Perhaps Egill Skalla-Grímsson here stands in for an older model of warrior-aristocrat casting judgment upon a group of rulers grown too mercantile and litigious. Given the widespread violence of the *Sturlungaöld*, it certainly seems possible that the past was also looked towards for models of leadership, and perhaps we see a romanticizing of martial virtue here, when chieftainship was becoming an increasingly less martial and more administrative office. In any case, Snorri’s acquisition of Reykholt shows us one of the main ways in which *goði* wealth could be acquired, and that it had much more to do with intelligent handling and negotiation than it had to do with feudal exploitation. As we shall see, however, economic exploitation is an ever-present source of danger and tension elsewhere in the saga material.

¹⁷³ Guðrún Ása Grímsdóttir, ed *Sturlunga saga*, §153.

The general consensus on the main source of *goði* wealth is land ownership.¹⁷⁴ As such, wealth was accumulated certainly not just through horizontal maneuvering alone, but also through vertical exploitation, specifically renting, or *fjárleigur*. The medieval law code *Grágás* gives us many details concerning the rights and duties of tenant farmers, suggesting the central importance of this economic relationship in medieval Icelandic life. Tenants were responsible for maintenance and upkeep of their property and ensuring that the hay was fully mown. Rental contracts were generally limited to one year, perhaps suggesting an unstable relationship.¹⁷⁵ Although we can doubtless say that the sagas reflect something like a “*goði* ideology,” there are nevertheless moments when other perspectives seem to “poke through” the narrative and make themselves known. One major way this occurs is in the tensions that arise between landlord and tenant. As is so often the case, our evidence is rather sparse, and straightforward rent-relationships appear to be relatively rare in the sagas.¹⁷⁶

One glimpse we have into landlord-tenant relations is in the beginning of *Brennu-Njáls saga*. Unnr seeks to separate from her husband, Hrútr, and Mǫrðr advises her to use Hrútr’s seasonal rent-collecting trip to the West Fjords as an occasion to leave him: “Síðan mun hann fara í fjörðu vestr ok Sigmundr með honum, ok mun hann flytja allt fé sitt vestan ór fjörðum ok vera í brautu lengi sumars.”¹⁷⁷ While there is little we can say about Hrútr’s treatment of his tenants from this passage, the trip serves a clear narrative function by acting as an opening for Unnr. By leaving his farmstead, Hrútr

¹⁷⁴Cf. Byock, *Medieval Iceland: Society, Sagas, and Power*. 101-2; Ross Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” in *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*. 169.

¹⁷⁵ Jón Jóhannesson. *History of the Old Icelandic Commonwealth*, 347.

¹⁷⁶ Samson, “Goðar: Democrats or Despots?” 180. In *From Sagas to Society: Comparative Approaches to Early Iceland*. Gísli Pálsson, ed.

¹⁷⁷ Einar Sveinsson, ed. *Brennu-Njáls saga*, §7.

exposes himself to the plans of his wife. Clearly, rent-collection reflects both a historical reality, but within the context of the literary world of the sagas, also serves a narrative function. We also have depictions of rent-collection in *Fljótsdæla saga*, a very young and incomplete saga, which serves as a continuation of *Hrafnkels saga Freysgoða*.¹⁷⁸ This is in itself interesting, as we have seen already the degree to which class dynamics are active in the former saga. It is perhaps possible that explicit depictions of rent-collection became more common with younger sagas due to the social changes we have outlined. The relevant scene in *Fljótsdæla saga* sees one Helgi Droplaugarson interrogating a Þorkell fullspakr on his travels. Þorkell tells Helgi that he is out to collect his rents, at which Helgi responds that it is not the correct time of year for such matters.¹⁷⁹ The scene suggests that most expected debts to be collected at specific times of the year, and that very often, these rent-collection trips are used as narrative devices for other purposes. Finally, we see several hints of an emerging class tension within some of the saga sources. *Sturlunga saga* has been identified as containing “Nietzschean resentment,” whereby farmers boast of the slaying of chieftain Sighvatr Sturluson.¹⁸⁰ Such “resentment” may indicate a growing sense that the social position of the chieftain class was unearned or otherwise illegitimate, and it speaks to the diverse nature of the sagas that this point of view is nevertheless able to be expressed in the very same literature which so often props up the image of the chieftain.

¹⁷⁸ Finlay, *Fljótsdæla saga*, 198. In *Routledge Encyclopedia of Medieval Scandinavia*.

¹⁷⁹ Jón Jóhannesson ed. *Fljótsdæla saga*, §18. In *Austfirðinga sögur*.

¹⁸⁰ Torfi Tulinius, “Legitimation and Its Problems,” 297. In *Nordic Elites in Transformation c. 1050–1250*.

Similar dynamics have also been located in *Brennu-Njáls saga*, highlighting the depiction of Valgarðr grái and his son Mörðr as instigators of particularly base plots.¹⁸¹

Section Conclusion

The social changes accompanying the *Sturlungaöld* saw a widespread consolidation in chieftain power and wealth across Iceland, centering especially around the acquisition of tithe-bearing church properties which allowed *goðar* to collect rents on behalf of the church and further consolidate their position. We have discussed how this bears broad similarities with continental patterns of landholding, and the possible importation of rulership ideologies from the continent.¹⁸² Aron Gurevich has described the aristocratic-warrior ethos which defined Western European feudalism as follows:

[T]he ruling class had nothing to do with productive activities of any kind and in so far as such activities were the province of the lower, unprivileged strata of society, tended to despise them. From the knightly point of view, only war, chivalric exploits and entertainment—what Marx trenchantly described as ‘heroic laziness’—qualified as occupations worthy of a nobleman; the provision of material comforts, the heavy, dirty jobs associated with growing food, were essentially the province of the common herd.¹⁸³

Notably, we might expect to see this “heroic laziness” in the sagas as rulership patterns became more and more unequal and chieftains became less involved with the daily realities of labor.¹⁸⁴ However, what we find in the saga sources seems to very much contradict this image. Regardless of the extent to which *goðar* were indeed involved with the management of their farms or not, it seems important to the *goði* self-image

¹⁸¹ Torfi Tulinius, “Legitimation and Its Problems,” 297. In *Nordic Elites in Transformation c. 1050–1250*.

¹⁸² Torfi Tulinius, *The Matter of the North*, 290–1.

¹⁸³ Gurevich, *Categories of Medieval Culture*, 259.

¹⁸⁴ Think, again, how we have an awareness that the sons of wealthy chieftains *no longer* work on the farm.

that they were still, indeed, farmers. This is perhaps surprising, as we might expect a different strategy of legitimation at the time in Icelandic history when chieftain power began concentrating, but farm labor remains a key way in which the chieftain class defines itself.

5. Conclusions

For an agrarian society such as medieval Iceland, agricultural labor must surely have represented a total view of reality for a great majority of the population. And yet, despite their unparalleled use as social documents, when we consider the sagas of Icelanders images of labor seem rather rare. On one level, this is merely the problem of historiography revisited—out of all the raw data of the chronicle, which are selected and woven into the narrative of history? The historian and author are always making choices, selecting things deemed interesting, and leaving things deemed less interesting out. The sagas can be said to have an epic conception of history, and their interest at a genre level is in travels, genealogy, feuds, and the like. It is perhaps no surprise then that this everyday background of life is often absent from these narratives—as a matter of genre, the sagas are simply not concerned with a detailed account of everyday life.

However, I believe that we have demonstrated that this genre-frame of the sagas is by no means a neutral one. On the one hand, we must consider the central role played by the contemporary chieftain class in literary production, and on the other hand, how the sagas have been received as reflecting a “*bóndi* ideology,” or else the myth of the “free Viking peasant.” This myth has enjoyed a long after-life in the scholarship, where liberal historiographers have stressed the centrality of independent farmers, relatively democratic decision making, and a relative absence of hierarchy in Scandinavian social history. The figure that has served to inspire this project, William Morris, was certainly influenced by this tradition, but his revolutionary Marxism also carried him beyond these liberal assumptions. We have begun this project with a consideration of his work precisely because of the central importance he placed on labor and its relationship to political liberty, and furthermore, how he projected these ideas onto the Iceland of the

saga-age. For Morris, Commonwealth Iceland represented a society with unalienated labor, and therefore freedom, at its very center. This was a medieval Iceland in which every man was his own sovereign, and this individual sovereignty was won through labor. To some extent, Morris' writings on saga-age Iceland mirror the self-perceptions of the saga authors themselves, as we see in so many prologues in the sagas that describe the settlement of Iceland as a flight from the tyranny of Haraldr Hárfagri in Norway to re-establish ancestral rights. For Morris, the saga authors, 19th century historiographers, and indeed many modern scholars, the settlement of Iceland has fundamentally been a story about freedom. Our goal, of course, has not been to undermine the actual historical role of free farmers, but rather to demonstrate the ways in which the myths of free Viking peasants have ultimately served to obscure the wider range of contemporary attitudes towards labor, privileging only one group and presenting a sometimes-romanticized view of social conditions in medieval Iceland.

I hope to have shown that far from a society of independent farmers who all owned the products of their own labor, that medieval Iceland was in the midst of a process of centralization, and importantly, that there seems to be an awareness of this in the medieval literature. To understand the saga worldview regarding these social changes, we have identified three major social groups: slaves, freemen, and chieftains, and discussed the representation of each group as it relates to labor. However, because of the occasional scarcity of source material we have not looked at just the literary representation of their labor, but also the literary representation of social relations more generally as it relates to these groups. Each of these groups have relationships to labor that are deemed appropriate and inappropriate. Slaves were constructed as being more embodied than others, this being a way to exclude them from the higher spheres of

freedom and political participation. As such, their labor belonged not to themselves, but their masters. Nonetheless, there are ways in which slaves make their agency felt in the saga narratives, including withholding their labor. Where this is represented as laziness, we may instead see a form of protest and agency exerting itself. Perhaps most interestingly, not all slaves are represented equally, and there seems to be a class of slave that still retains some of their agency, likely through their ethnic similarity to their masters. Crucially, these inwardly free slaves also retain the relationship to labor of that of a freeman. Of unlanded agricultural laborers we have seen a great variety of representations, but significantly, many of these revolve around inclusion and exclusion from the central farmstead. As we have discussed, the legal and social center of medieval Iceland was the farmstead and the conjugal pair at its center. Unlanded, itinerant workers were required to register at these farmsteads, but always stood in an uneasy relationship to their integration there. As such we see great anxiety regarding the dangers of socially unintegrated laborers. Finally, we have also considered the representations of chieftain-labor. This proves to be a special case, given the integral role of the chieftain class with saga production. Although we can certainly say that the sagas of Icelanders are in some sense an expression of a class identity, there is still an irreducible complexity in these narratives. The chieftain class were certainly emerging as something like a landed aristocracy by the time of Iceland's loss of independence. We have seen, for instance, how the sons of wealthy chieftains are said to no longer work on farms through passages that make gestures towards historical norms. Nevertheless, farming remains a central aspect of chieftain identity, and we see what may be a genuine pride in labor among the chieftain class. Far from showing only one

perspective, we have shown how these narratives also thematize class conflict and therefore can be said to represent more than just a chieftain interest.

The coming years are sure to bring a revolution into both the nature of labor and our relationship to it. Today, the worker faces unprecedented pressure, both from competition with workers abroad through globalization, and the increasing automation of the workplace. And yet, as this project is written, a new wave of class struggle is beginning to develop. The pandemic created the conditions for the greatest wave of unionization since the 1930's, and workers are beginning to challenge a labor landscape that has largely been in place since the neoliberal regimes of Reagan and Thatcher. This study has been written with these coming sea changes in mind, but I believe this project represents only a beginning attempt at a broader study of historical worldviews concerning labor. Here, I briefly sketch out what a future study may look like. As we have mentioned, women's labor has fallen outside the scope of our concern for practical reasons, but a more thorough study of women's labor must of course be part of any future project. Future consideration of the representation of labor in medieval Icelandic literature must also take a broader approach, both historically, geographically, and disciplinarily. We see for instance in art history a great interest in medieval calendars, manuscript illustrations, cathedral art, and other visual forms that thematize labor in both England and France, and such approaches may well shed light on the situation in medieval Iceland. As the future threatens such radical changes, it may well do good to look to medieval Iceland. This too was a society undergoing dramatic change, and I believe that we can read the sagas as an attempt to understand these changes in social relations and labor. We may not know what the future holds for our relationship to work, but perhaps in looking to the past, we may find something new.

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